Sunday, December 31, 2023
Poush 15, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Thingalaga Chaturthi

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 15 | Pages 8 | Rs. 5 | National Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: RSS

Chief Ministers of all seven provinces presenting a memorandum to Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' on full implementation of federalism by transferring power to provinces as mentioned in the Constitution at PM's official residence in Baluwatar, Kathmandu on Saturday.

Implementation of federalism my top priority: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 30

The Chief Ministers of all the seven provinces jointly met with Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' in Baluwatar on Saturday morning and drew attention of the federal government for the implementation of the federal rights guaranteed by the constitution.

The Chief Ministers submitted a seven-point letter to PM Prachanda and drew the attention of the government to arrange the use of the list of common rights provided in the constitution, and to implement the conclusions of the Chief Ministers' Conference held in Pokhara last June.

The Chief Ministers stressed that the creation of laws necessary for the implementation of federalism is not the sole responsibility of the Government of Nepal, but the joint responsibility of the federal parliament and political parties, and said that the Prime Minister should coordinate for political consensus.

While meeting with the Chief Ministers, Prime Minister Prachanda said that as he is a pioneer of federalism and also the leader of constitution making, he is serious about making federal laws.

He said, "As you know, I envisioned a federal republic and fought for it. I have played a role and taken the lead in writing it in the constitution. Therefore, the implementation of federalism is my greatest interest and priority."

"You are aware that I am working earnestly for the creation of laws related to the implementation of federalism, including the Federal Civil Service Act, Federal Education Act, and Police Adjustment Act," said the Prime Minister. Now they remain to be finalised through discussion. I will take further initiatives to resolve the problem after discussing it at the top political level, he said.

Poor policy backup, cumbersome process disappoint women entrepreneurs

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Dec. 30

Sharada Rijal, a successful entrepreneur in felt and handicraft sector, has a bitter experience while obtaining the incentives on exports from the government. She made rounds of banks, customs offices, business chambers and the Department of Industry (DoI) for about three years to get her share of incentives, ranging from 3-5 per cent on the basis of domestic raw materials used and value added, and decided to quit doing it.

"It did no good. There are lots of procedural hassles and complexities than the benefits," she said.

Similarly, Hira Bhattarai, an entrepreneur dealing in natural fibre, said that she hands over her products to an exporter based in Kathmandu who collects the products from the entrepreneurs like her and sells in the international market.

Struggling with skills gaps in trade, limited financing, and institutional neglect, women entrepreneurs in Nepal face barriers in productions and exports hindering business development. For example, all the incentives and benefits on exports are channelised to the exporters not to the producers.

About 29 per cent of the 922,356 enterprises established in the country are owned by women, and half of them grapple with informal operations and inadequate access to resources, raising concerns about gender equity in business.

Mobilisation of concessional loans (by mid-September 2023)

Loan Type	No. of Loans	Approved Loan
Commercial agriculture and livestock loan	57,780	162.77 billion
Educated youth self-employment loan	172	81.22 million
Returnee youth migrant project loan	879	720.28 million
Women entrepreneurship loan	82,323	86.8 billion
Dalit community enterprise development loan	998	697.38 million
Technical and business education loan	122	43.2 million
Housing loan to earthquake affected household	176	48.75 million
Garment industry loan	253	2.51 billion
Youth self-employment loan	53	30.2 million
Vocational training loan	2	400,000
Total	**144,758**	**253.72 billion**

Source: Nepal Rastra Bank

TRN SPECIAL

More women entrepreneurs face challenges in business skills, finance, technology, and limited access to resources compared to their male counterparts. Absence of institutional and policy support hampers access to finance, business development, and reinforces gender bias.

While many countries including in Africa and Asia-Pacific region have included gender in their trade policies, the Trade and Export Promotion Centre (TEPC) of Nepal said that incentives and promotions are provided to the businesses, not to males or females. "There is no gender in trade," said Sharad Bikram Rana, Executive Director of the TEPC.

It is not easy to obtain the government provided incentives on exports. Sharada Rijal, who is also the former President of the FWEAN, said that the banks, DoI, and other agencies are not supportive to women enetrepreneurs in terms of access to finance and international markets. "You need to have documents from a bank, customs office, national and local chamber (and handicraft association if the good falls in the category of handicraft), and DoI. It takes several days to fulfill the requirement and get the incentives," she said.

According to Rijal, many small women entrepreneurs are scared of the process and drop the idea of getting incentives and export their products through an exporter.

Likewise, Bhattarai, who is based in Pokhara, said, "It is difficult to conduct export business and obtain incentives. So trading through an export house seems easier and safer for many women entrepreneurs."

Lack of institutional support

Many women-led businesses operate informally and face constraints in access to loans from Banks and Financial Institutions (BFIs) due to collateral requirements while inadequate technology and marketing knowledge hinder the growth. According to the FWEAN, registration of women-owned and operated micro and cottage enterprises is way below the male-owned businesses although statistics are not available to validate it.

Despite existing institutions and policies promoting women's participation in various sectors, business remains an overlooked area, hindering desired expansion and growth for women in trade.

There are more than 22 institutions and mechanisms for the protection and realisation of women's rights, but none work for economic empowerment and inclusion. For example, National Women Commission (NWC), hasn't worked in the area of entrepreneurship except participating in a few consultation or discussion programmes organised by other stakeholders.

The Ministry of Women, Children and Senior Citizens (MoWCSC), in its 2020 report, has listed 13 legal instruments that help to ensure gender equality and empowerment of women and girls but except the Labour Act, 2017, all are related to issues like social discrimination, violence and education.

Likewise, international treaties and declarations that Nepal has signed so far also have orientation to the rights and violence, not to livelihood, economic opportunities and inclusion.

» SEE PAGE 6

Govt to provide Rs. 1 million to families of Balkumari incident victims

CDO, SP and EPS director of Lalitpur transferred

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 30

The government has expressed deep sorrows over the tragic death of Sujan Rawat of Dailekh and Birendra Shah of Achham in an incident that took place in Balkumari area of Lalitpur on Friday.

A meeting of the Council of Ministers held on Saturday passed a proposal towards this end, according to Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma said.

"The government has decided to pay tribute to the deceased and expressed heartfelt condolences to the bereaved families, and wished for the speedy recovery of the injured in the incident," said Minister Sharma after the Cabinet meeting. Minister Sharma said that the government has also decided to provide Rs. 1 million per family of the deceased.

"The government has also decided to bear all the medical expenses of the injured in the incident," said Minister Sharma. The Ministry of Finance will release the amount as announced by the government to the Ministry of Home Affairs. "The government is dedicated to conduct an impartial investigation regarding the incident and take strict action against the culprits," said Minister Sharma. The Ministry of Home Affairs will make the security and other related agencies more alert, restrained and effective to prevent incidents of such nature from happening in the future, the Minister said.

"As the government is committed to prevent such incidents from happening in the future and to maintain peace and security, we call on everyone to take the incident with moderation and prevent the deterioration of the peace and security environment," the government has urged.

Meanwhile, the Ministry of Home Affairs has removed the Chief District Officer, Chief of Lalitpur Police Range and Director of EPS Korea Branch of Lalitpur.

According to the Ministry of Home Affairs, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha has decided to remove Lalitpur Chief District Officer Rudra Prasad Pandit, District Police Range Chief of Lalitpur SSP Shiddhi Bikram Shah and EPS Korea Branch Director Gurudutta Subedi. CDO Pandit and SSP Shah were called at the Ministry and Police Headquarters respectively.

According to the Ministry, it has also decided to suspend DSP Umeshraj Lamsal and Physical Infrastructure and Transport Minister Prakash Jwala's Private Security Officer (PSO) Bodhraj Danuwar who were deployed in the field from Lalitpur Police.

The Home Minister took the decision after attending a meeting called by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' on Saturday morning in the presence of DPM Shrestha, DPM and Defence Minister Purna Bahadur Khadka, and other security chiefs of the Valley.

More than one million tourists arrive in 2023

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 30

More than one million foreign tourists came to visit Nepal via air in the year 2023. According to the statistics of the Nepal Tourism Board, 1,008,614 tourists came to Nepal as of 5:00 am on Saturday.

With this, the government's goal of bringing in one million foreign tourists in 2023 has been fulfilled. In the budget of the current fiscal year, the government had mentioned that the number of foreign tourists visiting Nepal would be increased to 0ne million in 2023.

The tourism of the country hit badly by the COVID-19 pandemic has almost revived to its original state. The NTB says that tourism has recovered this year by almost 85 percent.

In 2019, around 1.2 million foreign tourists had visited the country. "The arrival of tourists this year is encouraging", said NTB Director Maniraj Lamichhane. More than 1 million tourists have entered through the Tribhuvan International Airport in Kathmandu.

Likewise, president of Hotel Association of Nepal (HAN), Binayak Shah, expects the arrival of tourists to further increase in the coming days. If the government expands its partnership with the private sector, tourists will increase in the future.

It may be noted that the government has announced 2025 as the Visit Nepal Year. Furthermore, the year 2023 to 2032 is being celebrated as the tourism decade with a target of bringing in 3.5 million tourists. Meanwhile, the number of Indian tourists has increased significantly this year. In 2019, 254,150 Indian tourists came to Nepal while the number is 317,481 this year. Likewise, the number of American tourists reached 99,985 this year. In 2019, 93,241 American tourists had arrived to visit Nepal.

Likewise, the number of Chinese tourists is gradually increasing, with visits by 60,160 Chinese nationals this year. In 2019, 169,543 Chinese tourists had come to Nepal.

Most money for endangered species goes to few creatures, leaving others in limbo

AP
Billings, Mont., Dec. 30

Since passage of the Endangered Species Act 50 years ago, more than 1,700 plants, mammals, fish, insects and other species in the U.S. have been listed as threatened or endangered with extinction. Yet federal government data reveals striking disparities in how much money is allocated to save various biological kingdoms.

Of the roughly $1.2 billion a year spent on endangered and threatened species, about half goes toward recovery of just two types of fish: salmon and steelhead trout along the West Coast. Tens of millions of dollars go to other widely known animals including manatees, right whales, grizzly bears and spotted owls.

But the large sums directed toward a handful of species means others have gone neglected, in some cases for decades, as they teeter on potential extinction.



PHOTO: AP

This image released by the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service shows a flower from a shrub known as marrón bacora on March 21, 2021.

At the bottom of the spending list is the tiny Virginia fringed mountain snail, which had $100 spent on its behalf in 2020, according to the most recent data available. The underground-dwelling snail has been seen only once in the past 35 years, according to government records, yet it remains a step ahead of more than 200 imperiled plants, animals, fish and other creatures that had nothing spent on their behalf.

With climate change increasing threats to organisms around the planet and adding to the number that qualify for protection under the Endangered Species Act, government officials are struggling in many cases to execute recovery actions required under the law.

Some scientists even argue for spending less on costly efforts that may not work and putting the money toward species with less expensive recovery plans that have languished."For a tiny fraction of the budget going to spotted owls, we could save whole species of cacti that are less charismatic but have an order of magnitude smaller budget," said Leah Gerber, a professor of conservation science at Arizona State University.

» SEE PAGE 6

Furniture business an important sector of economy: Dr. Mahat



PHOTO: TRN

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat addressing the 9th annual general meeting of the Federation of Nepal Furniture and Furnishing Entrepreneurs Association in Kathmandu on Saturday.

We can become independent in the field of furniture. There is also a lot of potential for export as well. Nepal is also prosperous in terms of art and culture.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 30

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has said that furniture business is an important sector of economic activity. While addressing the 9th annual general meeting and the 5th convention of the Federation of Nepal Furniture and Furnishing Entrepreneurs Association, Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said, "Although 45 per cent of the land in Nepal is covered by forest, we do need to import furniture from abroad."

However, he said that importing furniture from abroad and using steel furniture instead of wood is not pleasant for us. "We can become independent in the field of furniture. There is also a lot of potential for export as well. Nepal is also prosperous in terms of art and culture. We can manufacture special types of furniture, which can be in high demand abroad," Minister Dr. Mahat said.

He said that the government is determined to encourage and promote the furniture and furnishing business. "According to the policy of the government, high customs duty is imposed on ready-made goods, but low customs duty is levied on imported raw materials. The government has adopted this policy so that this industry can flourish," he said.

Stating that there is a policy of the government to protect the domestic industry, he, however, noted that imported furniture was being used in government offices or private houses despite the government's policy. Even though the furniture imported from abroad looks good, it is not durable, he said.

Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said that it was important for us to inform the consumers about the quality differences of furniture and furnishing goods produced inside the country and imported from abroad.

"It has been said that there is a problem in the furniture industry due to laws, rules and regulations, and the government is trying to remove them. We should help facilitate the domestic industry," he said.

He said that the system of wood in the forest going to waste and not being used should be tackled. "We have to work to compete with imported goods. We have to be self-reliant in this business and export furniture abroad," he said.

'Economic revolution only after political revolution steer country to prosperity'

RSS
Dhulikhel, Dec. 30

Former Prime Minister Dr Baburam Bhatarai said the countries achieving higher level of progress through economic prosperity had first accomplished political revolution. At the academia industry gathering hosted by the Kathmandu University at Dhulikhel on Friday, Dr Bhattarai said.

He said that Nepal's economic development agendas have been relegated when political revolution did not steer to the right path. He urged the new generation to engage their efforts in creativity rather than indulging in abusing political workers and party leaders.

Noting that instability of political and democratic system was the main cause behind Nepal's laggard status in development, Dr Bhattarai said it was a matter of glory to come to the status of federal democratic republic today through political revolution.

"Democratic stability is a must in today's context when capital, technology and labour among others have been globalized", he said. Former Finance Minister Surendra Pandey said education sector was the largest industry in Nepal arguing the need of establishing academic institutions for progress and spurring education sector budget.

Noting that the universities should elevate their existing quality, he recommended the universities to actively expand their market reach. KU's Vice-Chancellor Prof Dr Bhola Thapa said the entire team of the university has engaged efforts for making wider publicity about the educational programmes being taught here.

He stressed the need to change tendency of putting pressure for student admission expressing surprise that no agency or actor has never asked for the specific human resource in job industry. "The country can be taken to the pathway to prosperity through job creation which is possible only in collaboration among the educational institutions, industry and government", Thapa added.

Also speaking on the occasion, Vice-Chairperson of Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry Surkrishna Baidhya commented that the country could not move to the economic revolution due to policy problems. Economic revolution sans industrial revolution is not possible he argued, calling for placing emphasis on promoting industrial sector and boosting confidence of industrialists.

KU's Registrar Prof Dr Achyut Wagle said the political parties should also emphatically incorporate the idea of academia industry in their manifestoes. "Education, family life and nation's development are deeply interconnected", he said.

Director-General of the Department of Industry, Baburam Gautam said the ministry was mooting measures such as software development, er-commerce related policy and other laws drafting for reforms in industrial sector.

Coordinator of KU Department of Academia Industry Collaboration, Dr Ram Lama shared that the KU has implemented special research and innovation programmes in the areas of technology, green energy and employment promotion.

Contractor leaves health post building construction in limbo

RSS
Khotang, Dec. 30

The construction of a health post's building at Rakhabangdel of Aishelukharka rural municipality in Khotang district has not made any headway due to gross negligence of the contractor company.

The Gauri Parbati New Technical JV was awarded contract on November 26, 2020 for the building by March 11, 2022. Chief of the project office in Okhaldunga, Prabhakar Karna, ranted that there was no alternative to bringing that erring contractor company to book. He shared that they had sent a follow-up letter for the last time to the company, warning it of action if the company persists inaction.

The wall of the ground floor has been plastered while there is no wall in the second floor. The same company had bagged the contract to construct altogether five buildings of different five health posts at the estimated cost of over Rs 74 million (excluding VAT), according to Karna.

NEA cuts power supply of 14 industries

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 30

The Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) has cut power supply of additional 14 industries. According to the NEA, it has cut power supply of additional 14 industries that consumed electricity from dedicated feeders and trunk lines in the past, but have not paid the premium fee.

The Authority cut the electricity lines of industries with power tariff arrears of more than Rs. 50 million under the dedicated feeders and trunk lines. The NEA started cutting the lines of industries who refused to pay power tariff from December 22, 2023.

In the first phase, electricity of four industries with arrears of more than Rs. 1 billion and then five industries was cut off. Along with 14 more industries whose power supply was cut on Friday, 23 industries getting power supply from dedicated feeder and trunk lines have been cut off.

The electricity supply of Baba Jute Mills (Rs. 56.1 million), Nigale Cement (Rs. 142.1 million), Triveni Synthetic Yarn Industries (Rs. 156.6 million), Himal Iron and Steel (Rs. 81.3 million), Jagdamba Enterprises (Rs. 476.6 million), Hama Iron (Rs. 115.5 million) and Everest paper Mills (Rs. 213.6 million) have been cut on Friday.

Similarly, electricity supply of Cosmos Cement (Rs. 358.2 million), Shubhashree Agni Cement (Rs. 381 million), Jagdamba Synthetic (Rs. 475.3 million), Gharana Foods (Rs. 50.9 million), Siddhartha PET Plast (Rs. 52.4 million), Butwal Cement (Rs. 329.8 million), Narayani Ispat (Rs. 784.9 million) has been cut.

The electricity tariff arrears of Jagdamba Steels stood at Rs. 4.14 billion, Reliance Spinning Mills at Rs. 1.94 billion, Ghorahi Cement at Rs. 1.36 billion and Arghakhanchi Cement at Rs. 1.3 billion. According to the Authority, 61 industries have to settle Rs. 22.24 billion in arrears.

After the NEA has started to cut electricity supply of industries having electricity arrears continuously, the private sector representatives on Friday met Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' and requested to resolve the dispute according to the legal system at the earliest.

They have drawn the attention of the Prime Minister to immediately connect the electricity of those industries whose line has been cut citing that there are arrears without actual basis and proof or non-payment of arrears.

Emphasis laid on women entrepreneurship

RSS
Pokhara, Dec. 30

Women tourism entrepreneurs have laid emphasis on need of special action plan from policy-level to promote women entrepreneurship for propping up economy. They stressed it at a programme organised for women entrepreneurs of service sector in Gandaki province. EU-Nepal Trade and Investment Project organised the event with coordination of Women Tourism Entrepreneurs Forum (WOTEF).

On the occasion, tourism entrepreneur Sharmila Neupane said the state has not been paying attention to the result-oriented activities. She mentioned, "The state should create gender-based investment-friendly environment in order to encourage women in entrepreneurship for social justice and equality." She went on to claim that there is no feeling about the presence of the government."

Also a tourism entrepreneur, Gandaki Province Assembly member, Devaka Pahari, shared that women are deprived of the opportunity to income generation in lack of women-friendly environment.

Pointing out the need of investment-friendly environment, policy to encourage entrepreneurship, guarantee of market, training as per women's interest, capacity enhancement, she said she had been constantly raising voice in this regard.

Similarly, Professor Dr Chandra Bhadra viewed that women are compelled to face discrimination due to various reasons after the state is not seen sensitive towards gender-friendly concept. Chairperson of Pokhara Tourism Council, Pom Narayan Shrestha, underscored that there are immense potentials to encourage women towards entrepreneurship as tourism is multi-dynamic sector. Sharing contribution of women tourism entrepreneurs in tourism promotion of Pokhara, she pointed out the need of additional empowerment of women.

Likewise, WOTEF Advisor Pampha Pahari opined that with the establishment of the organisation, collective voices are being raised for women empowerment. Organiation Chair Uma Bhandari Regmi said the organisation had been organising various programmes for augmenting status of women associated with different business. Women tourism entrepreneurs had gathered for the first time in Pokhara and established the organisation in 2074 BS.

She further said the state should pay attention to capacitate women entrepreneurs and manage sustainable finance. EU Representatives Dipanjali Shrestha shared that as per the statistics of Gandaki Province only around 45 per cent women are self-dependent.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Curio products showcased for tourists in Bashantapur Durbar Square area.

Farmers lured to fishery



RSS
Godawari (Kailali), Dec. 30

Farmers have been lured to fishery in Sudurpaschim Province of late. The fish farming is done in more than 200 natural ponds and hundred other commercial ponds. The government record shows 10,000 metric tons of fish is produced every year in the province.

Chief of the fishery development centre of Geta, Kailali, Surya Shahi, informed that Kailali and Kanchapur districts were being developed as centre for fishery in the province. The production has meeting almost 75 percent of the demand here, while 25 percent is imported from India and other provinces.

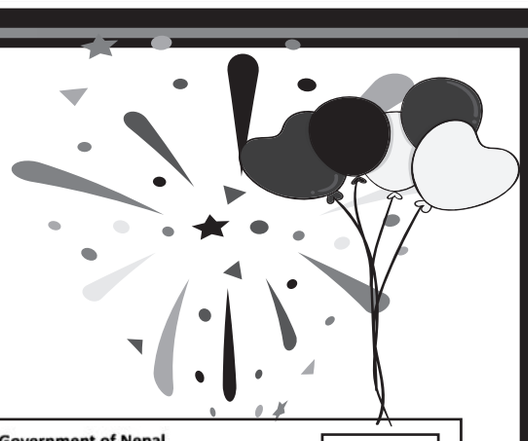
Even the consumption of this aquatic animal is on rise here. Annually, average consumption per person is two kg of fish. According to Office Chief Shahi, per person consumption of fish would be increased to 10 kg in coming 10 years. Similarly, the production of the aquatic animal is aimed at reaching 30,000 metric tons per a year in a decade.

However, the farmers have complained that they were not getting fries, feed and medication on time, while marketing is an equally pressing problem. The Centre further informed that around 4,800 metric tons of fish is consumed in Kailali and Kanchanpur annually. Fishery is being done in ponds constructed in 1,750 hectares of land in two districts.

Of 1,750 hectares of land, the natural ponds cover 1,304 hectares of land and artificial ponds 250 hectares of land. Three metric tons of fish per hectare is being produced in artificial ponds and one metric ton per hectare in the natural pond. The two districts used to import around 90 per cent fish from India before 10 years, which are now producing fries of different species. The Centre has been producing more fries than the target in the recent period and distributing to different districts.

Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal
Kathmandu

31ST December 2023



Kathmandu, Nepal



Prime Minister

Message

I would like to extend my heartfelt congratulations to Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal (CAAN) on the occasion of its Silver Jubilee celebration. On this special day, I would like to commend the role Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal has been playing as the leader of the aviation sector with its contribution for the regulation of overall aviation activities and impeccable commitment in infrastructure development. Nepal has difficult geographical terrain and has no reliable means of transportation for the remote areas in the hills and mountains, air services not only transports people and goods but also provides integrity, prosperity and unity to the people and country. The accessibility that air travel provides to these regions has been instrumental in bridging geographical gaps, fostering economic activities, and improving overall quality of life for the residents.

I would like to appreciate CAAN for its efforts in expanding services to remote areas of Nepal through aviation by facilitating all airline operators and ensuring strong public private cooperation. I want to express my gratitude for the crucial role that the aviation sector, under the auspices of CAAN, has played during times of disasters like earthquake and floods. The ability to swiftly mobilize resources, conduct search and rescue operations, and facilitate the transportation of relief materials has been vital in the aftermath of natural calamities. The aviation sector has proven to be a lifeline during times of crisis, showcasing its resilience and ability to contribute significantly to the nation's disaster response and recovery efforts.

Infrastructural development is paramount in a crucial sector such as aviation which connects people of all regions in the country. The leap CAAN has taken in the sector of infrastructural development in the recent years is commendable. I believe that Pokhara International Airport and Gautam Buddha International Airport coming into operation promising an increased connection with the international arena as well, the tourism sector is expected to be further benefitted.

I am hopeful that CAAN will continue to work to modernize and expand Nepal's aviation facilities to meet the demands of a growing economy, increasing trade and business activities, and a flourishing tourism sector. On this occasion of silver jubilee celebration, I want CAAN to reflect on the past achievements and weaknesses and devise even better policies for the rapid development of the aviation sector, facilitating the private sector companies and expansion of air services to new destinations around the globe. The adoption of advanced technologies and navigation systems is another avenue for future development. Embracing digital solutions can enhance operational efficiency, improve safety measures, and streamline air traffic control.

Finally, I would like to express my best wishes for every success of CAAN.

Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda'

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation
Singhadurbar, Kathmandu, Nepal



Message

I am delighted to extend my heartfelt congratulations to the Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal (CAAN) on the auspicious occasion of its Silver Jubilee celebration. This milestone marks 25 years of unwavering commitment, dedication, and execution of programs to ensure the safety and efficiency of Nepal's aviation sector. It has witnessed a remarkable journey in the past two and a half decades and paved the way for the development of the aviation sector in the country.

CAAN plays a pivotal role in facilitating and regulating air travel, an essential component of our thriving tourism industry, as well as the transportation of goods and people in remote areas that are not connected by quality road infrastructure. Nepal, with its breathtaking landscapes, rich cultural heritage, and warm hospitality, has become a coveted destination for travelers from across the globe. The aviation sector, under the vigilant oversight of CAAN, has played a crucial role in connecting our nation to the world and fostering economic growth through tourism.

The Silver Jubilee celebration is an opportune moment to reflect on the achievements of CAAN and the collaborative efforts that have propelled the aviation sector to new heights. The dedication of CAAN's personnel and their hard work have been instrumental in ensuring the smooth operation of air travel in Nepal. Likewise, the airline operators have not only been open to the adoption of modern technology and management practices in their operations but have also been supportive of the government and people during difficult times.

On this historic milestone, it is essential to acknowledge the challenges that the aviation industry has faced, especially in the wake of the global pandemic. The agility of CAAN and Nepali airline operators in responding to the evolving circumstances, implementing safety protocols, and contributing to the repatriation efforts has been commendable. The resilience demonstrated during these challenging times reflects the organization's commitment to its mission and the well-being of the nation.

I also would like to take this opportunity to mention that the operation of the Gautam Buddha International Airport and Pokhara International Airport would directly contribute to the growth of business as well as the tourism sector, while the proposed Nijgadh International Airport possesses the potential to become a hub in the region with increased air traffic and enhanced connectivity. These projects not only strengthen our position on the global aviation map but also open up new avenues for tourism, trade, and economic development.

On behalf of the Ministry of Culture, Tourism, and Civil Aviation and the Government of Nepal, I extend my sincere congratulations to CAAN on this occasion. I also appreciate the role of the aviation industry and concerned stakeholders, including companies and individuals, in advancing

This sector, I am happy with the publication of the souvenir that records the opinions of the experts in aviation.

I wish you a joyous celebration and hope for a greater contribution to the economic prosperity of the country in the days to come.

Sudan Kirati
Minister
Sudan Kirati
Minister

Phone No. : +977-1-4211879 (Office), Email : sudankirati2@gmail.com, Website : www.tourism.gov.np

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation
Singhadurbar, Kathmandu, Nepal



Message

I feel very excited to extend my heartfelt congratulations to the Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal (CAAN) on its 25th Anniversary. I am hopeful that this moment of silver jubilee celebration of the authority leading the aviation sector would be a turning point for new phase for the development of aviation sector in Nepal.

As the authority responsible for the safety and security of civil aviation in Nepal, CAAN has played a significant role in adopting international aviation safety measures and facilitating the airlines service provider in operating their business in the country. Safe and secure civil aviation facilitates tourism development, economic upliftment of people and employment generation.

The contribution of the aviation sector to Nepal's development cannot be overlooked. One of its primary roles is facilitating connectivity within the country, linking urban centers with remote and often inaccessible regions. The ability of air travel to transcend geographical barriers has opened up opportunities for economic development in areas that were once isolated. Villages tucked away in the Himalayas or nestled in the lowlands now have access to essential services, education, and healthcare, all because of the connectivity provided by air transportation.

The aviation sector in Nepal has emerged as a critical driver of the country's development, playing a pivotal role in connecting regions, fostering economic growth, and contributing significantly to the overall progress of the nation. While the sector has made notable strides, it is essential to acknowledge its weaknesses and explore the future prospects that can further elevate Nepal's aviation landscape.

Looking ahead, there are promising future prospects for Nepal's aviation sector. The ongoing infrastructure projects, once completed, will not only alleviate the existing constraints but also position Nepal as a regional aviation hub. Nijgadh International Airport, with its strategic location, has the potential to become a major transit point for international flights, further boosting connectivity and trade. Similarly, collaborations with the private sector can bring in the necessary expertise and investments to drive innovation and efficiency in the sector.

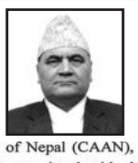
I am optimistic that CAAN will enhance its capability with support from the government, ICAO and other concerned organizations to cope with emerging challenges facing the civil aviation sector. Likewise, I am hopeful that there will be even better cooperation among the Tourism Ministry, CAAN, airline operators and stakeholders for the development of this sector.

I wish for the success of CAAN in its future endeavors.

Mrs. Sushila Serpali Thakuri
Honorable State Minister
Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation

Phone No. : +977-1-4211628 (Office), Email : serpalisushila1@gmail.com, Website : www.tourism.gov.np

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation
Singhadurbar, Kathmandu, Nepal



Message

On the occasion of the Silver Jubilee celebration of the Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal (CAAN), I extend my heartfelt congratulations and warm wishes to all entities and people associated with the aviation arena which has a pivotal role in up lifting Nepal's tourism and economic sectors.

The aviation sector, under the purview of CAAN, has been a driving force behind the development of Nepal as a premier tourist destination. The strategic expansion of aviation infrastructure underscores our commitment to providing better facilities for both domestic and international travelers. Airports are not just runways and terminals; they are gateways to the unparalleled beauty of our nation, inviting visitors to experience the rich cultural heritage, diverse landscapes, beautiful Himalayas and warm hospitality that Nepal has to offer.

The symbiotic relationship between aviation and tourism is undeniable, and CAAN's efforts have been instrumental in creating an environment that fosters growth, connectivity, and accessibility for travelers from around the globe. CAAN's role in facilitating the growth of tourism goes beyond infrastructure development. The commitment to ensuring safety, efficiency, and adherence to international standards has enhanced Nepal's reputation as a safe and welcoming destination.

Moreover, the aviation sector has been a catalyst for mobility, bringing people closer and connecting regions that were once remote. Air travel remains as a lifeline for communities in these regions, providing economic opportunities, healthcare access, and improved connectivity to the rest of the nation. The access thus created to reach various corners of Nepal has contributed to the growth of tourism segments such as adventure tourism, eco-tourism, and cultural tourism. Meanwhile, initiatives to develop international airports, regional airports and upgrade domestic airports will have significant impact on the development of aviation and tourism sectors in the country.

As we celebrate this Silver Jubilee, let us reflect on the achievements, challenges, and the path forward. Together, we can ensure that aviation remains a dynamic force in shaping Nepal's tourism landscape, contributing to economic growth, job creation, and the overall prosperity of our nation. The CAAN should enhance its capability to keep pace with the changing scenario of aviation sector, technological development, aviation safety and technology transfer. It also has the responsibility to set standards for the domestic and international airline operators, infrastructure development and production of skilled manpower.

I extend my warmest congratulations to the Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal on this occasion. May the coming years be marked by continued success, innovation, and collaboration, as we work together to realize the full potential of Nepal's aviation and tourism sectors.

I wish CAAN all the best for its future endeavors.

2023/12/27
Dr. Dipak Kaphle
Secretary

International Civil Aviation Organization | Organisation de l'aviation civile internationale | Organización de Aviación Civil Internacional | Международная организация гражданской авиации | منظمة الطيران المدني الدولي | 国际民用航空组织



Felicitations on the 25th Anniversary - Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal

On the occasion of the celebration of its 25th Anniversary on the 31st December 2023, I am deeply honored to convey on behalf of the International Civil Aviation Organization (ICAO) Asia and Pacific Regional Office, our felicitations to the Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal.

Year 2023 has been significant to the global aviation in the context that air transport continued to return to normalcy after the devastating COVID-19 pandemic though the pre-pandemic air transport performance is predicted only by 2025. The lessons learned however, must echo within us to remind everyone concerned that preparedness for any aviation related public health eventuality must be maintained and complacency must be avoided.

A sustainable and more resilient future for aviation is fully achievable, and to that end, ICAO has been working intensely and consistently together with the Member States and, other partners and stakeholders. States have also adopted some key strategic decisions last year in the triennial Assembly on how to better prepare the sector for future public health and other types of crises. In that regard, it is worth noting that innovation will be a critical component in assuring every passenger's expectation in terms of the safety, security, health, reliability, and convenience of their air travel experience. Upholding aviation safety and security as two key pillars for sustainable growth of air transport, ICAO has increasingly been providing States with implementation support with all the resources at its disposal to assist States to meet the global aviation targets and technology roadmaps stemming from the latest editions of the ICAO's Global Aviation Safety Plan (GASP) and Global Air Navigation Plan (GANP) as well as the Global Aviation Security Plan (GASeP).

The ICAO Regional Office for Asia and Pacific considers Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal an important partner of the international civil aviation community and rest assured the Regional Office remains available to support the Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal in your endeavors to strengthen the safety, security and efficiency of the international air transport system.

Lastly, I convey my gratitude to the Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal, and all of the colleagues and partners, for their contribution to make international civil aviation a stimulus for economic and social growth maintaining, at the same time, high standards of safety and security in all critical areas of aviation.

My best wishes for your 25th Anniversary celebrations.

Tao Ma
Regional Director
ICAO Asia and Pacific Office
26 December 2023

Asia and Pacific Office
252/1 Vibhavadi Rangsit Road
Chatuchak
Bangkok 10900
Thailand

Postal Address:
P.O. Box 11
Samyaek Ladprao
Bangkok 10901
Thailand

Tel.: +66 (2) 537-8189
Fax: +66 (2) 537-8199

www.icao.int/apac
E-mail: apac@icao.int

CIVIL AVIATION AUTHORITY OF NEPAL
Head Office, Babar Mahal, Kathmandu, Nepal

Phone : 4262326, 4262416, 4262518, 4262923, 4111119
Facsimile : (977)-1-4262516-
e-mail : cnsatm@mos.com.np
Cable : AIRCIVIL
AFTN : VNKTYAYX



Message

On this momentous occasion of completing 25 years, I extend my sincere congratulations to the entire Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal (CAAN) family, stakeholders from public and private sectors and international partners. This Silver Jubilee is a testament to the dedication, perseverance, and unwavering commitment that has shaped CAAN's excellence as the leader of the civil aviation sector in Nepal. As we celebrate this milestone, it is crucial to reflect on our achievements, acknowledge the challenges we've overcome, and look ahead with a vision for continued growth and development.

Aviation is an integral contributor to the development of the tourism industry, and we remain committed to playing a pivotal role in this regard. The seamless connectivity provided by air travel is a catalyst for tourism growth, facilitating the influx of visitors and contributing significantly to the economic prosperity of the nation. As we continue to develop and expand our aviation infrastructure, we envision a future where Nepal becomes a preferred destination for global travelers.

Moving forward, our focus remains on fostering collaboration with the private sector to ensure sustainable growth. We recognize the importance of public-private partnerships in leveraging resources, and innovation to enhance the overall efficiency and competitiveness of Nepal's aviation sector. CAAN's strategic planning includes establishing air links to remote areas, and diversifying our routes to cater to the evolving demands of passengers. This initiative not only promotes mobility within the country but also contributes to the growth of the tourism sector, allowing more people to experience the natural beauty and cultural richness that Nepal has to offer.

This year witnessed the completion of the construction of Pokhara International Airport and commencement of international operations from there, completion of structural reforms at the Tribhuvan International Airport and other domestic airports, operation of ATR-72 aircrafts at Surkhet and Tumlingtar airports, and enhancement of air navigation system in various airports.

CAAN has been playing major role for safer aviation with better regulation, compliance with ICAO mandates and adoption of international best practices. This year, we have plans for improvement works at more than one and a half dozen airports across the country. Our journey has been remarkable, and I am confident that with continued collaboration, innovation, and a shared vision, CAAN will be able to contribute to the prosperity and development of Nepal's aviation sector. With ongoing infrastructure projects, regulatory improvements, and strategic collaborations, the future prospects for Nepal's aviation sector are promising. A resilient and modern aviation industry is not only essential for economic growth but also for ensuring that Nepal remains a connected and accessible nation globally.

On this occasion, please allow me to express my gratitude and warm greetings to our clients, valued passengers, government and private sector companies, donors and other stakeholders in Nepal and abroad. Your support has always been instrumental for the growth of aviation sector and development in Nepal. I would also like to thank souvenir publication committee and the Silver Jubilee Celebration Committee of CAAN for the hard work they have put to make it happen.

Happy New Year 2024.

(Er. Pradeep Adhikari)
Director General

Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal

Brief Introduction of Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal (CAAN)

Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal was established as an autonomous entity on 31st December 1998 under the Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal Act, 1996. CAAN has been set up with the objective of ensuring civil aviation safe, secure, efficient, regular and environmentally sustainable. It has dual functions: Regulator as well as Air Navigation Service Provider (ANSP) with Aerodrome Operator.

A. Regulatory Functions:
- To regulate air transportation by ensuring the compliance of the international standards promulgated by International Civil Aviation Organization (ICAO) and National Civil Aviation Requirements.
- To issue the Operating Certificate to airlines and other aviation business.
- To inspect, monitor and oversight the flight safety and Aviation Security.
- To issue competency-based licence, rating and certificate, as prescribed, to Pilot, Engineer, ATS & Others Safety Sensitive as well as Technical Personnel.

B. Aerodrome Operations & Air Navigation Service Provider Functions:
- To conduct feasibility, consultation, construction, operation, management and maintenance of airports and other infrastructures along with passenger facilitation service.
- To provide ANS services for safe, reliable, standard, efficient and smooth air transportation.
- To provide standard trainings and perusals to human resources needed in civil aviation sector.
- To ensure proper sources and utilization of grants, loans, government's share for infrastructure development.
- To co- ordinate with different agencies and stakeholders for smooth airport operation and passenger facilitation.

C. International Responsibilities:
- To enforce guidelines and SARPs (Standard and Recommended Practices) of Convention on International Civil Aviation (Chicago Convention).
- To implement the Air Service Agreements & MOUs with respective countries.
- To co-ordinate with different national and international organizations for flight safety and aviation security.

Airports at a Glance:

International Airports
1. Tribhuvan International Airport
2. Gautam Buddha International Airport
3. Pokhara International Airport

Hub Airports
1. Biratnagar Airport 2. Nepalgunj Airport

Other Domestic Airports –
1. Baitadi
2. Bajhang
3. Bajura
4. Bharatpur
5. Bhojpur
6. Chandragadhi
7. Dang
8. Dhangadhi
9. Dolpa (Juphal)
10. Doti
11. Falgunanda
12. Gulmi Resunga
13. Janakpur
14. Jomsom
15. Jumla
16. Khanidanda
17. Phaplu
18. Pokhara
19. Rajbiraj
20. Ramechhap
21. Rara
22. Taplejung
23. Tenzing-Hillari (Lukla)
24. Thamkharka
25. Tumlingtar
26. Salle (Rukum)
27. Sanfebagar
28. Simara
29. Simikot
30. Surkhet

Domestic Airports (Not in Operation)
1. Baglung
2. Chaurjahari (Rukum)
3. Darchula
4. Dhorpatan
5. Palungtar (Gorkha)
6. Jiri
7. Kalikot
8. Kamal Bazaar
9. Kangeldanda
10. Khiji Chandeswori
11. Langtang
12. Lamidanda
13. Mahendranagar
14. Manang
15. Masinechar (Dolpa)
16. Meghauli
17. Rolpa
18. Rumjatar
19. Syangboche
20. Tikapur

Heliport – Nalinchowk

Domestic Airports Under Construction – Argakhanchi

Airport with RFF Facilities - 17

Airports with Night Operation Facilities –
1. Tribhuvan International Airport
2. Gautam Buddha International Airport
3. Pokhara International Airport
4. Biratnagar Airport
5. Chandragadhi Airport
6. Dhangadi Airport
7. Janakpur Airport
8. Nepalgunj Airport
9. Simara Airport

Domestic Airlines Operating in Nepal

Fixed Wing-9		Rotor Wing-12	
Buddha Air Pvt. Ltd.	Sita Air Pvt. Ltd.	Air Dynasty Heli Services Pvt. Ltd.	Manang Air Pvt. Ltd.
Guna Airlines	Summit Air Pvt. Ltd.	Altitude Air Pvt. Ltd.	Mountain Helicopters Pvt. Ltd.
Nepal Airlines Corporation	Saurya Airlines Pvt. Ltd.	Annapurna Helicopter Pvt. Ltd.	Mustang Helicopter Pvt. Ltd.
	Tara Air Pvt. Ltd.	Fishtail Air Pvt. Ltd.	Prabhu Helicopters Pvt. Ltd
Shree Airlines Pvt. Ltd.	Yeti Airlines Pvt. Ltd.	Heli Everest Pvt. Ltd.	Shree Airlines Pvt. Ltd.
		Kailash Helicopter Services Pvt. Ltd.	Simrik Air Pvt. Ltd.

International Airlines Operating in Nepal

S/N	Country	Airlines	Airlines
1	Nepal	Nepal Airlines Himalaya Airlines Buddha Air	3
2	India	Air India TATA SIA Airlines (Vistara) Indigo Aviation	3
3	Malaysia	Malindo Air Malaysia Airlines	2
4	UAE	Air Arabia Air Arabia Abu Dhabi Fly Dubai	3
5	Oman	Salam Air	1
6	Qatar	Qatar Airways	1
7	Singapore	Singapore Airlines	1
8	South Korea	Korean Air	1
9	Turkey	Turkish Airlines	1
10	Kuwait	Jazeera Airways Kuwait Airways	2
11	Sri Lanka	Sri Lankan Airlines	1
12	Bangladesh	Biman Bangladesh	1
13	China	Air China China Eastern Airlines China Southern Airlines Sichuan Airlines Cathay Pacific Airways Tibet Airlines	6
14	Bhutan	Druk Air Tashi Air	2
15	Thailand	Thai Airways Thai Lion	2
		Total	**30**

Paved Airports

S.N.	Aerodromes	District	S. N.	Aerodromes	District
1	Baitadi Airport	Baitadi	22	Lamidanda Airport	Khotang
2	Balewa Airport	Baglung	23	Manang (Humde) Airport	Manang
3	Bajhang Airport	Bajhang	24	Nepalgunj Airport	Banke
4	Bajura Airport	Bajura	25	Phaplu Airport	Solukhumbu
5	Bharatpur Airport	Chitwan	26	Pokhara International Airport	Kaski
6	Bhojpur Airport	Bhojpur	27	Pokhara Airport (Domestic)	Kaski
7	Biratnagar Airport	Morang	28	Rajbiraj Airport	Saptari
8	Chandragadhi Airport	Jhapa	29	Ramechhap Airport	Ramechhap
9	Dang Airport	Dang	30	Rara Airport	Mugu
10	Dolpa (Juphal) Airport	Dolpa	31	Rukum Chaurjahari Airport	Western Rukum
11	Dolpa (Masinechaur) Airport	Dolpa	32	Rukum Salley Airport	Eastern Rukum
12	Doti Airport	Doti	33	Rumjatar Airport	Okhaldunga
13	Dhangadhi Airport	Dhangadhi	34	Sanfebagar Airport	Accham
14	Gautam Buddha International Airport	Rupandehi	35	Simara Airport	Bara
15	Gulmi (Resunga) Airport	Gulmi	36	Simikot Airport	Humla
16	Ilam (Sukilumba) Airport	Ilam	37	Surkhet Airport	Surkhet
17	Janakpur Airport	Janakpur	38	Taplejung Airport	Taplejung
18	Jomsom Airport	Mustang	39	Tenzing Hillary (Lukla) Airport	Solukhumbu
19	Jumla Airport	Jumla	40	Thamkharka Airport	Khotang
20	Khanidanda (Manamaya Rai) Airport	Khotang	41	Tumlingtar Airport	Sankhuwasabha
21	Kalikot Airport	Kalikot	42	Tribhuvan International Airport	Kathmandu

Air Service Agreements

S.N.	Country	ASA/MoU Date of Signing	S.N.	Country	ASA/MoU Date of Signing
1	Australia	30 September 2019	22	Malaysia	5 Aug 2003
2	Austria	6 August 1997	23	Maldives	27 September 1984
3	Bahrain	26 Nov. 1997	24	Myanmar	26 August 1996
4	Bangladesh	2 April 1976	25	Netherlands	17 April 1998
5	Bhutan	25 December 1988	26	New Zealand	22 October 2015
6	Brunei	10 July 1986	27	Oman	2 December 1997
7	Cambodia	29 November 2018	28	Pakistan	24 August 1976
8	China	24 Jan 1987	29	Philippines	18 November 2004
9	Croatia	30 Mar 2004	30	Qatar	4 June 1995
10	Egypt	30 August 1995	31	Republic of Korea	12 February 1988
11	France	7 July 1998	32	Russian Federation	28 July 1989
12	Germany	19 March 1987	33	Rwanda	5 December 2023
13	Hong Kong (SAR)	19 August 1982	34	Saudi Arabia	4 October 1999
14	India	26 November 1964	35	Singapore	15 June 1984
15	Israel	19 Nov 2002	36	Sri Lanka	19 February 1977
16	Italy	8 May 1992	37	Thailand	14 January 1971
17	Japan	11 February 1988	38	United Arab Emirates	13 October 1999
18	Jordan	6 October 1999	39	United Kingdom	19 August 1982
19	Kuwait	10 October 1999	40	Vietnam	20 October 2015
20	Luxembourg	22 August 1997	41	Turkey	24 September 2010
21	Macau	28 October 1996			

Air Traffic Scenario (International and Hub Airports till 2023 Jan-Oct):

S. N	Airport Name	Aircraft Movement			Passenger Movement			Cargo Movement (In Kgs)		
		Arr	Dep	Total	In	Out	Total	In	Out	Total
1	TIA International	12837	12837	25674	1720918	1958687	3679605	9608405	9690212	19298617
2	TIA Domestic	39319	39344	78663	1668027	1676275	3344302	752718	1934533	2687251
3	GBIA	3946	3946	7892	225039	220834	445873	290452.85	105774.97	396227.82
4	PIA	7588	7271	14859	354144	377276	731420	172623.7	67053.49	239677.19
5	Nepalgunj	5266	5304	10570	192239	193516	385755	304235	745538	1049773
6	Biratnagar	4789	4786	9575	276483	272523	549006	259248.74	195608.22	454856.96

Stats (2079/80):

- Total number of Domestic Passengers – 44.66 Lakhs
- Total number of International Passengers – 34.88 Lakhs
- Total Airports Upgraded in 2079/80 – 37
- Total Available Seats for International Airlines – 87 Lakhs

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

You must do the things you think you cannot do.
- Eleanor Roosevelt

EDITORIAL

Check Crusher Plants

Illegally operating crusher industries and illegal and unsustainable extraction of riverine materials are rampant throughout the country, inviting serious environmental degradation. News reports on illegally operating crusher industries and illegal extraction of riverbed materials from Ratu River in Surkhet district in west Nepal, published in this daily recently, bring to light the continuing irregularities in these area. The illegal operation of crusher industries, and the fowl means they use to influence the local leaders to gain the contract is an open secret and this trend is rampant not only in this area alone. The exploitation of the gift of nature has been happening almost everywhere in recent times.

Barahatal Rural Municipality in Surkhet has informed that four crusher industries were operating illegally between Thapadera and Dokpa areas, and these industries have posed a risk to about 400 households along the banks of the Bheri River. It's a mockery of the rule of law taking place in a broad daylight. This happens because millions are made out of these ventures. Bribery, threat and power misuse and other illegal means are applied to bend the law. Multiple inspections have been carried out by the officials of the District Administration and District Coordination Committee, but no legal action has been taken against such industries. Citizens suspect that there is underlying corruption and irregularities while calling for tender, and the whole procedure of the contract.

The illegal extraction of riverine materials from various river without properly carrying out Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) has disturbed the ecosystem of the river, posing grave risk to the settlement on the banks. The dust and mud generated while extracting and processing such materials has polluted both water and air. Illegal and uncontrolled mining of construction materials from rivers under political protection has invited grave risks to the local settlements, aqua life, river ecology, healthy air and peaceful environment. Operation of illegal crusher plants pose a threat to sustainable development. Development needs to be modelled in such a way it does not bring destruction and environmental chaos.

Conservationists opine that the purely money-minded extraction of riverine materials is counterproductive and catastrophic for the environment in the long run. A few months back, the government lifted a ban on the extraction of riverine products and people in power are saying utilisation of available natural resources is a must to carry out development works and for a mountainous country like ours. Such a point of view is shortsighted and need rethinking. Nepal is rich in natural resources but the unsustainable method of utilising them can bring catastrophic results. We are already seeing undesirable trends in the environment amid global warming and climate change.

The change in precipitation patterns and high precipitation over a short period of time cause devastating floods and landslides in Nepal almost every year. Climate change has affected agricultural yields, food production, and natural ecosystem. We have put forward our climate concerns at COP 28 summit and strongly raised the challenges faced by mountainous countries like Nepal, but during this process we have overlooked the issue of illegal extraction of riverine materials that damages our environment. Thus, the government should appropriately deal with the issues of illegal crusher industries and help conserve the nature and ecology.

Climate Summit Results

HANS DEMBOWSKI

Greenhouse-gas emissions have kept increasing, reaching yet another record high in 2023. Global temperatures also reached a new record level, and the impacts of climate change are felt around the world as we see an increasing number of extreme-weather disasters. The original idea was that the UNFCCC should stop this deadly trend. Adaptation to a warming climate was initially left off the agenda, because it was not supposed to become necessary. It did, so, not quite 20 years after Rio, adaptation became an important topic of climate summits. Measures – and funding – again proved to be insufficient, so now a Loss and Damage Fund had to be launched, and it will require much more money that it has so far.

Had emissions been reduced as intended, money would neither have been needed to make infrastructure climate resilient nor for compensating the harm done by extreme weather. The UNFCCC did make a difference. Without it, our situation would be even worse. Its consistent pattern, however, is "too little, too late". That proved true once more at the Dubai climate summit in December. It did not decide to phase out fossil fuels, but only to transition away from them. That is better than nothing, but it does not suggest that we will see the decisive action that we so urgently need. It is more likely that matters will keep getting worse and we don't know when – or even whether – they might start getting better again.

It is easy to blame the high-income nations. Yes, they are guilty of doing "too little, too late". They still are reducing emissions too slowly and are too stingy when it comes to the financial support less fortunate countries need to cope with damages and adapt to warming. The full truth is that low-income countries have contributed very little to cause climate change but are especially vulnerable to its impacts. Middle-income countries, however, must bear some of the blame too.

It is striking that we have not seen a coherent and ambitious climate agenda being launched by the BRICS, the group of large emerging markets that includes Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa and claims to speak for the global south. Three members – Russia, India and China – are among the top five emitters in absolute terms. Two of them have disproportionately large carbon footprints per capita. India's case is special – its huge emissions result from its huge population. Its individual carbon footprint has tripled since 1990, bit still is merely 1.9 tonnes. On average, every Russian emits an annual 13 tonnes, slightly less than people in the USA do (14.4 tonnes).

China's per capita carbon footprint is 8.9 tonnes, which is almost twice the global average and slightly above the German figure of 8.2 tonnes. The Russia-Ukraine war is as carbon intensive as it is bloody. At their most recent summit in South Africa, the BRICS decided a few other countries to their group, including three petrostates: Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates and Iran. This choice shows that they are quite eager to keep accessing and using fossil fuels, but much less interested in democratic governance.

Saudi Arabia (17 tonnes of carbon emission per year and person) and the UAE (22 tonnes) are high-income countries. The BRICS have failed to explain how their closer alignment with the OPEC will help climate-vulnerable communities in Africa, Asia and Latin America. If the international community is to keep global heating below 1.5°C, we must escape this pattern. Western high-income nations must do more, and so must each and every government that claims to represent the global south.

- Development and Cooperation

Respect Religious Sentiments Of All

Ritu Raj Subedi



As Nepal heads to consolidate the federal republican system, various latent conflicts have come to the fore. These conflicts range from distribution of powers and resources between the provinces and federation to the flare-up of the religious and identity disputes at the local level. Chief Ministers have been flexing muscles against the centre, demanding the necessary laws that equip them with legal, administrative and financial rights. These unintended developments belie the logic that the underlying structural problems would be resolved once the federal, republican and secular system is operationalised. No doubt, the country has undergone transformative political changes but the gap between the commitment and performance of the leadership has largely been blamed for the emerging mess.

Moreover, anarchy, indiscipline and behavioural deviation are also upsetting peace and moral ethos required for democratic nation building task. Discipline and respect for law are essential for democracy and constitutional norms to thrive and deepen. Nepali society is still laden with multiple fault lines at different layers. The country conducted two three-tier governments but the elected leaderships have not been able to translate the constitutional provisions into action. The situation is getting worse as the people in the responsible positions step out of line, triggering controversy and disturbing social harmony.

Irrational remarks

Just a few days back, a sitting minister, who also looks after the cultural affairs, stirred up a hornet's nest by hurting the feelings of Hindus, who constitute over 80 per cent population in the country. He ran the gauntlet of public wrath. While the social media was filled with vitriolic criticisms and disapprovals of minister remarks, various pro-Hindu organisations and political parties sought action against him. His statements were not only irrational but also contained elements of incitement in the society. The sad part is that the minister continued to defend his remarks instead of apologising to the public. On the other hand, party with whom the minister is associated did not come up with a statement to contradict the minister's remarks.

Similarly, the appointment of Laxmi Pun as executive director of Pashupati Area Development Trust (PADT) has courted controversy as Hindu supporters have claimed that she is a Christian and does not fit in that post. Lawmakers have crossed swords over Pun's religious faith at a meeting of the International Relation and Tourism Committee of parliament that recently called the PADT's office-bearers to enquire about her appointment. A lawmaker from Rastriya Prajatantra Party claimed that Pun was a Christian and her appointment as the PADT chief was an insult to Hindus.

However, a female lawmaker of the CPN-Maoist Centre said that there was no ground of the accusation against Pun. She insisted it was unfair to question the integrity of Pun just because she is a woman. The Committee had instructed the concerned ministry and PADT to submit documents related to Pun's appointment, academic certificates, experience certificates and personal details within three days.

> Adherence to basic constitutional values, tolerance and regard for popular sovereignty is equally important. Failure to embrace these principles will invite anarchy, aberration, frustration and street protests.

Sometime back, Dharan Sub-metropolitan City Mayor Harka Sampang had removed the pictures of the President and Prime Minister and hung the photograph of ancient Kirat king of Kathmandu Valley - Yalambar. Sampang, who won the election as independent candidate, has openly challenged the authority of the centre. Writing on his Facebook page, he said that he would fix the pictures of heads of state and government only when the centre gives importance to Dharan. Apparently, the move is a part of his protest against the federal government. But the way he contested federal government has put him in hot water. Mayor Sampang is known for his eccentric acts and rants, which have led to decline in his popularity he attained during and after the election.

This is not the first time elected representatives have been dragged into controversy for removing the photos of the heads of state and government. Some months ago, Kathmandu Metropolitan City Mayor Balen Shah had put up a picture of Greater Nepal instead of the President and Prime Minister in his chamber. Balen's step came in response to the Indian government's decision to display a mural that includes Nepal's territories, including Kapilvastu and Lumbini in its newly built parliament building. Unlike Sampang, Balen still commands popularity for his unorthodox style of working. But his rude manner of criticising the big parties also got him into trouble.

Negative implications

The controversies surrounding the people's religious faith bear negative implications for the society. They do not only undermine the spirit of secularism but also give credence to the argument that secularism was not adopted through a due process. This distasteful scenario comes to light at a time when the voices against secularism and republican set-up are heard in the streets. The social fabric weakens if religious sentiments of people are hurt knowingly and unknowingly.

Nepal's constitution has envisaged cooperative federalism in which three-tier of governments have specified rights, powers, resources and jurisdictions. At the heart of decentralisation of powers lies the philosophy that the federal governance is capable of addressing the inherent disparities and providing justice to the marginalised communities. However, this administrative arrangement is not only expensive and complex but also demands broader understanding, mutual cooperation and political culture. Adherence to basic constitutional values, tolerance and regard for popular sovereignty is equally important. Failure to embrace these principles will invite anarchy, aberration, frustration and street protests.

(The author is Deputy Executive Editor of this daily.)

Physical Activity Boosts Personal Health

Dr. Shyam P Lohani



Physical inactivity is a major risk factor for non-communicable diseases (NCDs) such as cardiovascular disease, diabetes, and cancer. According to the World Health Organisation (WHO, 2022), physical inactivity is the fourth leading risk factor for global mortality, accounting for an estimated 3.2 million deaths annually. Despite the well-established health benefits of physical activity, a large proportion of the global population remains physically inactive. In this background, let us discuss the risks of physical inactivity on NCDs and the importance of promoting physical activity as a preventive measure.

According to the WHO, one in four adults and around 81 per cent of adolescents globally do not meet the recommended amount of physical activity. A recent study in Nepal revealed that about 8 per cent of males and 31 per cent of females had low physical activity. The same study depicted that about 31 per cent of adolescents and 14 per cent of young adults did not meet the WHO recommendations for physical activity.

Epidemics

Global mortality data revealed that cardiovascular disease (CVD) is the leading cause of death globally, accounting for 17.9 million deaths in 2019. Physical inactivity is a major risk factor for CVD, increasing the risk of developing hypertension, dyslipidemia, and obesity. Regular physical activity can reduce the risk of CVD by improving cardiovascular health, reducing blood pressure, and improving lipid profiles. A meta-analysis of randomised controlled trials found that physical activity interventions resulted in a significant reduction in the risk of CVD events and a reduction in the risk of CVD mortality. In addition, physical activity can improve the management of CVD risk factors such as diabetes and obesity.

People who perform a moderate level of physical activity have reduced chances of many cancers such as breast, bladder, stomach, lung, colon, and kidney, etc. It also helps in improving physical fitness, well-being, and quality of life among cancer survivors.

Increased sedentary behaviour and spending more time sitting in chairs with computers are destined to be associated with increased risks for weight gain, heart disease, type 2 diabetes, and premature death, to name a few. The effects of physical inactivity start shortly within as early as 3 to 4 weeks. Obesity and physical activity are interlinked. The risk of obesity is four times higher among physically inactive individuals.

Physical inactivity is associated with insulin resistance which is accountable for the development of type 2 diabetes. Therefore, a moderate level of physical activity greatly reduces the chances of type 2 diabetes and it also helps maintain blood sugar levels in patients with type 2 diabetes. Diabetes is a major public health concern, affecting an estimated 463 million people globally. Physical inactivity is a significant risk factor for type 2 diabetes, increasing the risk by up to 50 per cent. Physical activity can improve glucose control, reduce insulin resistance, and prevent the development of type 2 diabetes.

Cancer is the second leading cause of death globally, accounting for 9.6 million deaths in 2018. Physical inactivity is a significant risk factor for several types of cancer, including breast, colon, and lung cancer. Physical activity can reduce the risk of cancer by improving immune function, reducing inflammation, and regulating hormone levels.

> Physical activity can improve glucose control, reduce insulin resistance, and prevent the development of type 2 diabetes.

Physical inactivity is also a significant risk factor for mental health disorders such as depression and anxiety. Regular physical activity has been associated with improvement of mood, reduction of stress, and better cognitive function. It has been found that physical activity interventions resulted in a significant reduction in symptoms of depression and anxiety. In addition, physical activity can improve the management of mental health disorders by reducing the need for medication and improving overall quality of life.

Despite the well-established health benefits of physical activity, a large proportion of the global population remains physically inactive. According to the WHO, 1 in 4 adults worldwide do not meet the recommended levels of physical activity. In addition, physical inactivity is more prevalent in low- and middle-income countries, where the burden of NCDs is highest. The COVID-19 pandemic has further exacerbated the problem of physical inactivity, with lockdowns and social distancing measures limiting opportunities for physical activity.

Promoting physical activity as a preventive measure for NCDs is crucial for reducing the global burden of disease. The WHO recommends that adults aged 18-64 should engage in at least 150 minutes of moderate-intensity aerobic physical activity per week, or at least 75 minutes of vigorous-intensity aerobic physical activity per week. Moreover, muscle-strengthening activities have been recommended at least twice per week. Children and adolescents should engage in at least 60 minutes of moderate-to-vigorous physical activity per day.

Approaches

To promote physical activity, a multi-sectoral approach is needed, involving governments, healthcare providers, schools, workplaces, and the community. Governments can implement policies to create supportive environments for physical activity, such as building safe and accessible infrastructure for walking and cycling and promoting physical activity in schools and workplaces. Healthcare providers can provide physical activity counselling and referrals to exercise programmes. Schools can provide physical education classes and opportunities for physical activity during recess and after-school programmes. Workplaces can provide opportunities for physical activity during breaks and lunchtime. The community can organise physical activity events and promote active transportation.

Thus, physical inactivity is a major risk factor for NCDs, causing significant morbidity and mortality worldwide. Promoting physical activity as a preventive measure is crucial for reducing the global burden of disease. A multi-sectoral approach is needed to create supportive environments for physical activity and promote physical activity at the individual, community, and population levels. By promoting physical activity, we can improve the health and well-being of individuals and communities worldwide.

(Dr. Lohani is the executive director at the Health Concern, Nepal. lohanis@gmail.com)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

December 31, 1973

Anti-Nationals Condemned

Dhankuta, Dec. 30: The 21st session of district assembly has strongly condemned the anti-national elements who a few days ago created disturbances in Marong Rani police station and Nepal Rastra bank building, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.
Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Stop Delaying Climate Action



PHOTO: AP

This is in reference to the news report *"Wild weather leave at least 10 dead in Australian states"* published in this daily on Dec. 28. Climate change, the modern scourge, is showing its dreadful face all over the world after playing havoc in Himachal, Sikkim, Uttarakhand, Orissa, Tamil Nadu in neighbouring India, and many parts of the US and continental Europe, including France and Germany.

Even as we speak on the death and destruction that can unravel in our country from the loss of mass on the Himalayan glaciers owing to the onslaught of climate change, much of the world experiences the fury of unpredictable weather patterns.

What does this mean? We should be on our guard and take all preventive steps in the country without panic. That, however, does not mean we should procrastinate on taking steps to delay the effects of climate wrath locally.

Some of the steps we can take urgently without waiting for COP28 windfalls are planting millions of trees, avoiding massive environmentally hostile infrastructure, a blanket ban on the exploitation of natural resources, controlling land plotting, barring population migration beyond the natural capacity, among others.

Manohar Shrestha
Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

There were two guys working for the city. One would dig a hole -- he would dig, dig, dig.

The other would come behind him and fill the hole -- fill, fill, fill. These two men worked furiously; one digging a hole, the other filling it up again.

A man was watching from the sidewalk and couldn't believe how hard these men were working, but couldn't understand what they were doing. Finally he had to ask them.

He said to the hole digger, "I appreciate how hard you work, but what are you doing? You dig a hole and your partner comes behind you and fills it up again!"

The hole digger replied, "Oh yeah, must look funny, but the guy who plants the trees is sick today."

Biden government approves new weapons sales to Israel

AP
Deir Al-Balah, Gaza Strip, Dec. 30

The State Department said Friday that Secretary of State Antony Blinken told Congress he approved a $147.5 million sale for equipment, including fuses, charges and primers, that is needed for 155 mm shells Israel bought previously.

It marked the second time this month that the Biden administration is bypassing Congress to approve an emergency weapons sale to Israel.

The department cited the "urgency of Israel's defensive needs" as a reason for the approval, and argued that "it is vital to U.S. national interests to ensure Israel is able to defend itself against the threats it faces."

The emergency determination means the purchase will bypass the congressional review requirement for foreign military sales. Such determinations are rare, but not unprecedented, when administrations see an urgent need for weapons to be delivered without waiting for lawmakers' approval.

Blinken made a similar decision on Dec. 9 to approve the sale to Israel of nearly 14,000 rounds of tank ammunition worth more than $106 million.

Both moves have come as President Joe Biden's request for a nearly $106 billion aid package for Ukraine, Israel and other national security needs remains stalled in Congress, caught up in a debate over U.S. immigration policy and border security. Some Democratic lawmakers have spoken of making the proposed $14.3 billion in American assistance to its Mideast ally contingent on concrete steps by Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's government to reduce civilian casualties in Gaza during the war with Hamas.

Israeli warplanes struck two urban refugee camps in central Gaza on Saturday, as the Biden administration approved a new emergency weapons sale to Israel despite persistent international cease-fire calls over mounting civilian deaths, hunger and mass displacement in the enclave.

Israel says it is determined to pursue its unprecedented air and ground offensive until it has dismantled Hamas, a goal viewed by some as unattainable because of the militant group's deep roots in Palestinian society. The United States has shielded Israel diplomatically and has continued to supply weapons.

Israel argues that ending the war now would mean victory for Hamas, a stance shared by the Biden administration which at the same time urged Israel to do more to avoid harm to Palestinian civilians.



PHOTO: AP

Palestinian woman wounded in the Israeli bombardment of the Gaza Strip receives treatment at the Nasser hospital in Khan Younis, southern Gaza Strip, Friday, Dec. 29, 2023.

The war, triggered by the deadly Oct. 7 Hamas attack on southern Israel, has displaced some 85% of the Gaza Strip's 2.3 million residents, sending swells of people seeking shelter in Israeli-designated safe areas that the military has nevertheless also bombed. That has left Palestinians with a harrowing sense that nowhere is safe in the tiny enclave.

Residents in the urban refugee camps of Nuseirat and Bureij, two recent hot spots of combat, reported Israeli airstrikes overnight and into Saturday.

Nuseirat resident Mustafa Abu Wawee said a strike hit the home of one of his relatives, killing two people.

A second strike late Friday in Nuseirat targeted the home of a journalist for Al-Quds TV, a channel linked to the group Islamic Jihad whose militants also participated in the Oct. 7 attack. The channel said the journalist, Jaber Abu Hadros and six members of his family were killed.

Bureij resident Rami Abu Mosab said sounds of gunfire echoed across the camp overnight, followed by heavy airstrikes Saturday.

With Israeli forces pushing deeper into Khan Younis and the camps of central Gaza, tens of thousands of Palestinians streamed into the already crowded city of Rafah at the southernmost end of Gaza in recent days.

CHINA EXPELS NINE ARMY OFFICIALS FROM PARLIAMENT

AFP
Beijing, Dec. 30

China has expelled nine military officials from its parliament, including four generals of the army's strategic missile unit, in a sweeping reshuffle following the appointment of a new defence minister.

The decision, announced late on Friday by the state news agency Xinhua, came after a meeting of the Central Committee of the ruling Communist Party.

No explanation was given for the officials' removal.

Their removal is one of a series of high-level restructuring moves in the military establishment since defence minister Li Shangfu was abruptly sacked in October following months of speculation about his whereabouts.

Appointed in March, Li disappeared from public view in August before being formally dismissed in October.

On Friday Beijing appointed Dong Jun as the new defence minister, ending a months-long vacancy in the strategic post. Recent months have also seen an overhaul in the leadership of China's secretive Rocket Force, the army unit that oversees Beijing's nuclear arsenal, following media reports of a corruption probe involving its former chief.

British warship arrives near Guyana, fuelling tensions with Venezuela



PHOTO: AFP

Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro (left) and Guyana's President Irfaan Ali met in December 2023 and agreed not to use force to settle the territorial dispute.

AFP
Guyana, Dec. 30

A British warship arrived off the coast of Guyana on Friday, further fuelling tensions over a territorial dispute with Venezuela, which has launched a major military exercise in response to what it termed an "unacceptable" threat.

Venezuela and Guyana have been locked in a land dispute over the oil-rich Essequibo region which makes up about two-thirds of Guyana's territory, but has long been claimed by Caracas.

Venezuela's President Nicolas Maduro on Thursday ordered over 5,600 troops to join a "defensive" exercise near the Guyana border, in response to Britain sending a warship to the area in a show of support to its former colony.

Britain said Friday the Venezuelan military exercises were "unjustified and should cease."

London diverted the patrol vessel HMS Trent to Guyana "as part of a series of engagements in the region during her Atlantic patrol task deployment."

A Guyana foreign ministry source, speaking on condition of anonymity, confirmed the "uneventful" arrival of the warship in its waters on Friday.

Brazil, which borders both countries and whose President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva has emerged as a peace broker of sorts, on Friday called for "restraint and a return to dialogue."

Expressing "concern," the Brazilian government said in a statement it "believes military demonstrations of support to either party should be avoided."

Rocio San Miguel, a Venezuelan military expert and normally a critic of the government, said Britain's military response was "recklessness that forces Venezuela to respond as it has done."

However Gary Best, a former chief of staff of the Guyanan Defence Forces, said having the British ship in their waters was not "a provocation."

"It is nothing unusual. However, in the actual context... of the challenge to the sovereignty by Venezuela, it has taken on a new meaning.

"I can see how they would see it as a threat."

He said the military exercises were "a show of force" from Maduro, ahead of elections in 2024.

Venezuela's century-old claim on Essequibo has been revived since massive offshore oil deposits were discovered in the region and Guyana began handing out licenses to oil companies to operate there.

Maduro's government held a controversial referendum on December 3 in which 95 percent of voters, according to officials, supported declaring Venezuela the rightful owner of Essequibo.

He has since started legal manoeuvres to create a Venezuelan province in Essequibo and ordered the state oil company to issue licenses for extracting crude in the region.

Guyana, a former British and Dutch colony, insists the Essequibo frontiers were determined by an arbitration panel in 1899.

But Venezuela claims the Essequibo River to the region's east forms a natural border recognized as far back as 1777.

Brazil urged both parties to respect an agreement reached after Maduro and Guyana President Irfaan Ali met earlier this month in the Caribbean, where they vowed not to resort to force to settle the dispute.

Bosnian Serb leader Dodik vows to tear his country apart

AP
Bosnia-Herzegovina, Dec. 30

The Bosnian Serbs' separatist leader vowed to carry on weakening his war-scarred country to the point where it will tear apart, despite a pledge by the United States to prevent such an outcome.

"I am not irrational, I know that America's response will be to use force ... but I have no reason to be frightened by that into sacrificing (Serb) national interests," Milorad Dodik, the president of Bosnia's Serb-run part, told The Associated Press in an interview Friday.

He said any attempt to use international intervention to further strengthen Bosnia's shared, multiethnic institutions will be met by Bosnian Serb decision to abandon them completely and take the country back to the state of disunity and dysfunction it was in at the end of its brutal interethnic war in the 1990s.

Because Western democracies will not be agreeable to that, he added, "in the next stage, we will be forced by their reaction to declare full independence" of the Serb-controlled regions of Bosnia.

The Bosnian War started in 1992 when Belgrade-backed Bosnian Serbs tried to create an "ethnically pure" region with the aim of joining neighbouring Serbia by killing and expelling the country's Croats and Bosniaks, who are mostly Muslims. More than 100,000 people were killed and upward of 2 million, or over half of the country's population, were driven from their homes before a peace agreement was reached in Dayton, Ohio, late in 1995.

The agreement divided Bosnia into two entities — the Serb-run Republika Srpska and the Bosniak-Croat Federation — which were given wide autonomy but remained linked by some shared, multiethnic institutions. It also instituted the Office of the High Representative, an international body charged with shepherding the implementation of the peace agreement that was given broad powers to impose laws or dismiss officials who undermined the fragile post-war ethnic balance, including judges, civil servants, and members of parliament.

Over the years, the OHR has pressured Bosnia's bickering ethnic leaders to build shared, state-wide institutions, including the army, intelligence and security agencies, the top judiciary and the tax administration. However, further bolstering of the existing institutions and the creation of new ones is required if Bosnia is to reach its declared goal of joining the European Union.



PHOTO: AP

Bosnian Serb leader Milorad Dodik speaks during an interview with the Associated Press, in the Bosnian town of Banja Luka, 240 kms northwest of Sarajevo, Friday, Dec. 29, 2023.

PRISM

Snake stows away from Mexico to Canada

Mexico: A worker at a fruit and produce distribution centre in Ontario made a surprising discovery in a box of tomatillos: a snake that stowed away from Mexico.

The Toronto Wildlife Centre said in an Instagram post that a food terminal employee named Troy called the Wildlife Hotline for help when he opened a box of green tomatillos and came face to face with an orange and brown serpent.

The snake, identified as a northern cat-eyed snake, apparently had stowed away from Mexico to Canada with the produce.

"Although the veterinary team confirmed the snake was in good health, he was still a long way from home," the post said. "Our team is currently working on a plan to return this accidental traveller back to his native environment."

Shivering coyote rescued from frigid Lake

New York: Animal rescuers in New York came to the rescue of a coyote found stranded on a log in the frigid waters of Lake Erie.

The SPCA serving Erie County said in a news release that it was contacted by the state Department of Environmental Conservation about a stranded coyote spotted by Coast Guard officers near their Fuhrmann Boulevard station.

Lindsey Wood, the SPCA's chief investigations officer, arrived with her team to find the coyote was stranded on a log tied to a dock. Wood said the coyote initially fled into the 43-degree water.

"Thankfully, she realized as soon as she did that was a horrible decision and she turned immediately around, tried to crawl back on the log again, and that's when I snared her," Wood told The Buffalo News.

The rescuers determined the coyote was shivering from the cold and was exhausted from being stranded in the water for about three hours.

(Agencies)

TODAY IN HISTORY

406 – Vandals, Alans and Suebians cross the Rhine, beginning an invasion of Gaul.
1501 – The First Battle of Cannanore commences, seeing the first use of the naval line of battle.[citation needed
1600 – The British East India Company is chartered.
1687 – The first Huguenots set sail from France to the Cape of Good Hope.
1757 – Empress Elizabeth I of Russia issues her ukase incorporating Königsberg into Russia.
1759 – Arthur Guinness signs a 9,000-year lease at £45 per annum and starts brewing Guinness.
1796 – The incorporation of Baltimore as a city.
1831 – Gramercy Park is deeded to New York City.
1878 – Karl Benz, working in Mannheim, Germany, files for a patent on his first reliable two-stroke gas engine. He was granted the patent in 1879.
1879 – Thomas Edison demonstrates incandescent lighting to the public for the first time, in Menlo Park, New Jersey.

AIR RAIDS OVER EASTERN SYRIA KILL 6 MILITANTS

AP
Baghdad, Dec. 30

Three overnight airstrikes on eastern Syria Saturday near a strategic border crossing with Iraq killed six Iran-backed militants, two members of Iraqi militia groups told The Associated Press.

The strikes on the border region of Boukamal came hours after an umbrella group of Iran-backed Iraqi militants — known as the Islamic Resistance — claimed an attack on a U.S. military base in the city of Irbil in northern Iraq. The group has conducted over a hundred attacks on U.S. positions in Iraq and eastern Syria since the onset of the Hamas-Israel war on Oct. 7.

Four of the killed were from Lebanon's powerful Hezbollah group while the other two militants were Syrian, the militants said. They spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not cleared to talk to the press. Another two were injured, they added.

Moscow accuses Kyiv of shelling Russian border city of Belgorod

AP
Moscow, Dec. 30

Russian officials on Saturday accused Ukrainian forces of shelling the Russian border city of Belgorod, a day after an 18-hour aerial Russian barrage across Ukraine killed at least 39 civilians.

Two children were killed in Belgorod, regional governor Vyacheslav Gladkov said in a statement on social media. He also said that an unspecified number of people had been injured.

While previous attacks on the region have generally taken place at night, images on social media showed flames in broad daylight in what appeared to be the heart of the city, with cars set alight and plumes of black smoke rising among damaged buildings.

Air raid sirens sounded across the city, state media reported.

Earlier on Saturday, Moscow officials had reported shooting down 32 Ukrainian drones over the country's Moscow, Bryansk, Oryol, and Kursk regions.

They also reported that cross-border shelling had killed two people in Russia. A man died and four other people were injured when a missile struck a private home in the Belgorod region late Friday evening and a 9-year-old was killed in a separate incident in the Bryansk region.

Cities across western Russia have come under regular attack from drones since May, with Russian officials blaming Kyiv. Ukrainian officials never acknowledge responsibility for attacks on Russian territory or the Crimean peninsula.

> Cities across western Russia have come under regular attack from drones since May, with Russian officials blaming Kyiv. Ukrainian officials never acknowledge responsibility for attacks on Russian territory or the Crimean peninsula.

However, larger aerial strikes against Russia have previously followed heavy assaults on Ukrainian cities.

Russian drone strikes against Ukraine continued Saturday, with the General Staff of the Ukrainian Armed Forces reporting that 10 Iranian-made Shahed drones had been shot down across the Kherson, Khmelnytskyi, and Mykolaiv regions.

On Friday, Moscow's forces launched 122 missiles and dozens of drones across Ukraine, an onslaught described by one air force official as the biggest aerial barrage of the war.

As well as the 39 deaths, at least 160 people were wounded and an unknown number were buried under rubble in the assault, which damaged a maternity hospital, apartment blocks, and schools.

Western officials and analysts recently warned that Russia limited its cruise missile strikes for months in an apparent effort to build up stockpiles for massive strikes during the winter, hoping to break the Ukrainians' spirit.

Fighting along the front line is largely bogged down by winter weather after Ukraine's summer counteroffensive failed to make a significant breakthrough along the roughly 1,000-kilometer (620-mile) line of contact.

Russia's ongoing aerial attacks have also sparked concern for Ukraine's neighbors.

Poland's defense forces said Friday that an unknown object had entered the country's airspace before vanishing off radars, and that all indications pointed to it being a Russian missile.

Speaking to Russian state media outlet RIA Novosti Saturday, Russia's Charge d'Affaires in Poland, Andrei Ordash, said that Moscow would not comment on the event until Warsaw had given the Kremlin evidence of an airspace violation.

"We will not give any explanations until we are presented with concrete evidence because these accusations are unsubstantiated," he said.



PHOTO: RSS

People of Gurung community participating in a cultural programme organised on the occasion of Tamu Lhosar festival in Chitwan on Saturday.

7,000 shelters built in Rukum West for quake victims

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Rukum West, Dec. 30

Around 7,079 temporary houses have been built in Rukum West with the grant given by the government to the earthquake victims, and an additional 9,341 temporary houses are under construction.

According to Hari Prasad Pant, Chief District Officer (CDO) of Rukum West, Rs. 592 million has been transferred from the District Disaster Fund to the Local Disaster Fund so far, but only seven thousand houses have been built with the grant amount.

According to the District Administration Office, 3,014 temporary shelters have been built in Athabiskot Municipality and 4,100 shelters are under construction.

In Chaurjahari Municipality, 265 constructions have been completed and 2,400 constructions are under construction. Similarly, in Musikot Municipality, only 24 have been constructed so far and 48 are being constructed.

Similarly, 3,042 temporary houses have been constructed in Saniveri Rural Municipality so far and an additional 2,203 are being built. In Triveni Rural Municipality, 617 houses have been built and 550 houses are under construction.

Similarly, 117 buildings have been built in Banphikot Rural Municipality and 40 buildings are under construction.

CDO Pant said that the amount of the first instalment for 23,608 beneficiaries from the District Disaster Fund has been sent to the respective Local Disaster Fund. The local level has deposited Rs. 493 million in the accounts of 19,717 beneficiaries.

In Chaurjahari Municipality, Rs. 150 million have been sent from the District Disaster Fund for 6,279 beneficiaries, while the municipality has collected Rs. 148.4 in the accounts of 5,938 beneficiaries. Rs. 175 million sent for 7,000 beneficiaries in Aathbiskot Municipality has been fully deposited in the accounts of the benificaries.

PM Prachanda vows solution to labour problems

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 30

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said he was striving to address the rights of working class people.

Addressing the 6th national trade union conference organized by the Joint Trade Union Coordination Centre (JTUCC) here today, PM Dahal reminded that he was accorded utmost priority to labour sector in his past one year in office. He committed to making policy and programmes friendly to the workers.

The PM further argued the present government is the most favourable one to the labourers.

"I am firm to resolve genuine demands of the workers including formation of constitutional national labour commission with quasi-judicial rights and representation of 10 percent representation of working class in each state mechanism," Dahal pledged, warning of action to the employers who fail to enlist employees under social security scheme.

The PM reminded that contribution-based social security scheme was put in place for the welfare of the workers and labourers in the informal sectors in the country and abroad. The government stands by the workers and their genuine agenda and demands.

The foreign migrants and their rights were given priority. Help desks were set up at embassies and diplomatic missions and passport and visa process made easy, according to the PM.

PM Prachanda claimed that some important standards were set in areas of political stability, economic reform, guarantee of good-governance, public service delivery and social justice among others within a year of the formation of the incumbent government he is leading.

PM Prachanda, however, expressed, "I am not satisfied with this. I have announced some new resolutions for the coming years. It will be my top priority to materialize those resolutions, thereby spreading the rays of hope and laying foundation for prosperity in the country."

Similarly, FNCCI President Chandra Prasad Dhakal said that the employers were moving ahead in coordination with the worker class. He expressed his confidence that the agreement inked between the FNCCI and the JTUCC would facilitate in improving the relations between the employers and workers.

NC meeting concludes

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 30

The central working committee meeting of the ruling Nepali Congress concluded on Saturday night taking various decisions.

After the three-day meeting, NC publicity department chief Meen Bishwokarma informed that the party would make the decisions of its CWC meeting public on Sunday by organising a press meet.

The meeting also drew the attention of the government on its performance, the economic situation of the country and the incident of Balkumari of Lalitpur in which two youth were killed in police actions.

The meeting also decided to pick the National Assembly member candidates from the party on the basis of their contribution, geography and inclusiveness.

Bishwokarma told The Rising Nepal that the meeting decided to make the Mahasamiti meeting a success with adequate preparations.

Issues like running the 'NC in community campaign', and the contributions of the party workers in rescue, relief and rehabilitation of the Jajarkot earthquake victims were also discussed. The party also decided to celebrate the National Reconciliation Day on Sunday.

Poor policy backup, cumbersome process...

To formalise the women-run businesses, enhance participation of women in economic activities and decision making, support in poverty alleviation, and promote entrepreneurship, some fabourable policies are needed to create an equitable society.

According to the World Trade Organisation (WTO), trade policies can affect men and women differently, with women facing higher obstacles to taking part in the global economy and world trade.

"Increasing women's participation in the labour market could increase countries' productivity and trade opportunities, leading to greater economic diversification, innovation and poverty reduction," it said.

Women entrepreneurs are provided opportunity to represent on the boards of the Department of Industry, a council led by the Prime Minister and many other public committees but facilitation in marketing, promotion and trade fairs is weak. Immediate Past President of the FWEAN, Niru Rayamajhi Khatri, said that such inclusion in high-level committees is yet to be proven useful in formulating women-friendly policies.

The government had announced to establish a Women Craft Village at the Bhrikutimandap Exhibition Centre in Kathmandu but there has been no progress on the project so far. Women exporters like Rijal and Bhattarai said that the domestic as well as international trade fairs and business expos are instrumental in finding new customers and markets, and forge business-to-business relations. However, the government funding to support entrepreneurs in participating in international fairs has been decreasing in recent years.

According to Rayamajhi, the FWEAN is operating an online platform to showcase the products produced by the women entrepreneurs which has been effective in their promotion. "They can get connected with their customers in an economic way. We have organised an online expo of their products as well," she stated. The platform has helped many entrepreneurs to showcase their products and have buyers from Nepal and abroad.

Poor access to finance

The FWEAN estimated that only about 5 per cent of the 247,880 – about 29 per cent of the total 922,356 enterprises in the country, as per the Economic Census 2018 conducted by the National Statistics Office (NSO) - have obtained bank loan making the businesses having access to finance just 12,000.

Jiblal Bhusal, Joint Secretary at the Ministry of Industry Commerce and Supplies (MoICS), said that there are other programmes like the Rs. 230 million Women Entrepreneurship Fund to support women entrepreneurs.

"Meanwhile, the government is training women entrepreneurs on digital accounting system, providing discounts in business registration and facilitating them with institutional support by establishing a special unit at the Women Ministry," he said. However, there are no special provisions for women entrepreneurs in startup enterprise development loan and other similar policies.

Concessional loan to women

Authorities in the government and Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB) cite the concessional loan to women as one of the most important programmes in promoting women entrepreneurship. Under this facility, women entrepreneurship loan would come with 6 per cent interest subsidy, informed Dr. Gunakar Bhatta, Spokesperson of the NRB.

The subsidy is provided to the BFIs for this concession. By mid-September 2023, the number of women obtaining the Women Entrepreneurship Loan from the BFIs has reached 83,323 and Rs. 86.80 billion has been already mobilised in this sector. Two years ago, the number of women obtaining the loan facility was 66,690 and total mobilised amount was Rs. 69.21 billion.

According to the statistics published by the NRB, BFIs have approved approximately 144,758 loans worth Rs. 253.72 billion under the category of concessional loans including in agriculture and enterprise of returnee migrant workers, dalits and other businesses till mid-September this year.

Statistics show that the number of loans for women entrepreneurship tops the list of all concessional loans although the amount is higher in commercial agriculture and livestock loan category where the BFIs have mobilised Rs. 162.77 billion by mid-September 2023.

Although the impact of the loans given in the name of women entrepreneurship is not measured empirically, it has contributed significantly to financial literacy and inclusion, said Sunil KC, President of the Nepal Bankers Association (NBA).

He said that while it is also true that a part of such loans is obtained by women but used by male members in the family or business, its repayment ratio is better compared to other loan products. It has helped in promoting women entrepreneurship and empowerment in the society.

The loan provided to single women is given with a concession of 1 per cent on the interest rate.

Likewise, as per the Directives, class 'A', 'B' and 'C' BFIs are required to provide minimum 5 per cent of their total loan to deprived sectors, which include women from socially backward background as well as Rs. 2 million loan to micro industries and self-employed businesses run by women entrepreneurs.

Policies limited to rhetoric

The Industry and Investment Promotion Fund, provisioned by the Industrial Enterprise Act, 2020, should have representation of the FWEAN and female experts from the industry.

The proposed Fund which is yet to be created is likely to support women entrepreneurs as it will provide financial support for the development of micro, cottage and small industries, development of technology, rehabilitation of sick industries and advancement of women entrepreneurship.

The law has also clauses for tax exemptions, facilities or concessions relating to income tax and other liabilities but they are designed only for large-scale industries employing above 300 workers.

Similarly, the National Intellectual Property Policy, 2017 aims to identify, promote and develop creative industries from cultural sector, and provide free of cost legal and technical consultancy services pertaining to intellectual property and its protection for differently abled, dalits, marginalised communities, and women.

The President Women Upliftment Programme (PWUP), launched in 2017 and expanded to 34 districts, has a component to focus on livelihood improvement, employment generation and entrepreneurship to transform the life of disadvantaged, poor and marginalised women.

According to the Ministry of Women, Children and Senior Citizens (MoWCSC), the PWUP also includes programmes to organise exhibition of the goods produced by women entrepreneurs and establish sales centres at each province and national level. Similarly, trainings would be organised in the areas of women entrepreneurship and financial access.

Likewise, Trade Deficit Minimization Procedure 2079, has announced support for the national and international promotion of goods produced by women entrepreneurs via e-haat bazar. But it has not come into operation yet.

Give preference to women

A World Trade Organization (WTO) research paper published in 2019 has suggested that the government should provide quota or preference in favour of women entrepreneurs, financial support and incentives to women-led Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs), help in developing skills to access international markets, and promote women's empowerment in export sector.

According to the WTO, countries have simplified business license procedures for women entrepreneurs, involved ministries and governmental agencies responsible for gender equality in trade formulation and implementation, and invested in trade capacity building.

The South Asia Watch on Trade Economics and Environment (SAWTEE), a regional trade think tank, has suggested bridging women's access gap in finance and markets, supporting in the marketing of products, increasing use of online technologies, setting up special funding vehicle, and implementing gender sensitive policy making.

Former President of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI), Bhawani Rana, said that women entrepreneurs have been left behind despite the country having some favourable policies in absence of their effective implementation.

"Many women entrepreneurs have had unpleasant experience while obtaining the facilities announced by the government including tax discount and incentives on exports," she said.

Rana stated that in order to empower women in business, they should be formalised in the first place, and all stakeholders should come together to make this happen.

Immediate Past President of the FWEAN, Niru Rayamajhi Khatri also said that the process to obtain the incentives on export is cumbersome and takes a long time. "It is not women entrepreneur friendly," she said. She also added that such complexities have forced the producers and exporters quit the sector and become an importer and trader.

Most money for endangered...

An Associated Press analysis of 2020 data found fish got 67% of the spending, the majority for several dozen salmon and steelhead populations in California, Oregon and Washington.

Mammals were a distant second with 7% of spending and birds had about 5%. Insects received just 0.5% of the money and plants about 2%. Not included in those percentages is money divided among multiple species.

Species drawing no spending at all included stoneflies threatened by climate change in Montana's Glacier National Park, the stocky California tiger salamander that has lost ground to development and flowering plants such as the scrub lupine around Orlando, Florida, where native habitat has been converted for theme parks.

Such spending inequities are longstanding and reflect a combination of biological realities and political pressures. Restoring salmon and steelhead populations is expensive because they are widespread and hemmed in by massive hydroelectric dams. They also have a broad political constituency with Native American tribes and commercial fishing interests that want fisheries restored.

Congress over decades has sent massive sums of money to agencies such as the Bonneville Power Administration that operate dams along rivers the fish once traveled up to spawn. The money pays for fish ladders around dams, habitat restoration projects, monitoring by scientists and other needs.

More than half the species protected under the Endangered Species Act are plants, but the entire plant kingdom was almost excluded from the landmark conservation law when it was adopted in 1973, according to the Congressional Record and Faith Campbell, who interviewed people involved in the bill's passage for a 1988 study published in the Pace Environmental Law Review.

Plants initially were left out when the measure passed the Senate, with opposition led by influential Republican Sen. Ted Stevens of Alaska. They were added back at the 11th hour following a push by botanists from the Smithsonian Institution and Lee Talbot, a senior scientist at the White House Council on Environmental Quality, according to Campbell.

Botanists at the time proposed more than 2,500 plants as threatened with future extinction. However, most failed to get protections because federal officials failed to act prior to a Congressional deadline.

Today more than 900 trees, ferns, flowers and other flora are protected. Combined, they received about $26 million in 2020.

"In terms of numbers they're catching up, but as far as money and attention they're still not getting their share," said Campbell, a longtime environmental advocate who now works at the Center for Invasive Species Prevention. "The threats are serious, they're the same as the threats to animals. Yet they don't have the political clout of, say, a couple dozen of the big animal species that attract favorable attention or get in people's way."

Most plants receive less money than recommended under their recovery plans, according to Gerber and others. Researchers say that has direct consequences: species tend to decline when allocated less funding than needed, while they have a higher chance of recovery when receiving enough money.

Gerber has suggested redirecting some money from species getting more than their recovery plans seek — the bull trout, the gopher tortoise and the Northern spotted owl among them — to those receiving little or none. Her ideas have stirred pushback from some conservationists.

Former U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service Director Jamie Rappaport Clark said debating how to allocate scarce resources for rescuing endangered species is a distraction.

"The issue is not where the money is spent," said Clark, now president of Defenders of Wildlife. "The issue is that there isn't nearly enough of it."

Gerber said she doesn't want to let anything go extinct but that a strategic approach is needed with the shortage of resources.

"Unfortunately, the clock is ticking," she added. "We need to take action."

Wildlife officials say they are trying to do just that with money for endangered species in the climate law signed last year by President Joe Biden.It included $62.5 million officials said will allow them to hire biologists to craft recovery plans to guide future conservation work, initially for 32 species and for as many as 300 over coming years.

Among them are a colorful fish known as the candy darter that lives in rivers in the southeastern U.S., a flowering shrub from the Virgin Islands called marron bacora, the Panama City crayfish of Florida and the pocket-sized Stephens' kangaroo rat in southern California.

5:55 Drops Inspiring New Single 'Speed'

BY MANNU SHAHI



Born on July 12, 1993, Chirag Singh Khadka, better known by his stage name 5:55, is a Nepali rapper, composer and musician. Though his music career commenced in 2013, the singer's first big break came six years and multiple publications later, with the successful single 'Budi,' that has accumulated over 46 million views on YouTube to date.

The tune accentuated his Nepali-style delivery and the catchy hook with astonishingly produced video appealed to a large demographic. This video almost single-handedly established 5:55 as a potent figure in the Nep-hop industry.

And things have only escalated for the emcee since then.

It has been almost five years since 'Budi,' but 5:55 remains as relevant as ever, producing tons of music, touring and experimenting with different story-telling mediums.

He has crafted a discography consisting of 19 singles and his recently published 11-track debut album "Cosmic Soul" (2023). The emcee teamed up with Bluesss, Dj Nikz and Lil Rock Look for music production and audio arrangement for the album.

The rapper views writing as a medium for expressing his thoughts, and chooses to pen down his emotions as frequently as possible. Discarding the orthodox practices of gatekeeping in music, the songster believes that anyone with things to say can create music, regardless of their "caliber" and materialize a significant expression for themselves. He even feels this to be the template that has shaped his musical endeavours and claims that he was lucky in receiving such generous feedback for pursuing his desires.

A spiritually-inclined individual who believes energy influences creativity, 5:55 came forth with his 20th single last Monday on the occasion of Christmas. Titled 'Speed,' it is currently trending at #3 for music, as per Nepal-moderated YouTube charts. The first release from his upcoming sophomore album "The Change"; the song is produced by 1Bula, recorded by Bluesss and mixed by Minusdbstu. The video is shot and edited by Abhiyan Thapa (Abboye).

The singer dedicates this song to those who never give up, and continue to work on themselves and manifest their dreams. The lyrics, too, illustrate a narrative related to hustle culture, individual pace and relentless dedication to accomplish one's goals.

The song starts slow with minimal guitar pieces layered over wind sounds, the melodic fill flowing right over the reggae accompanying strum in the back. Vocals arrive as the hook takes over and the rest of the arrangement also surfaces. Embellishing keyboard melody in the hook, supporting yet not over-shadowing the guitar works, complementing vocal harmonies oozes Rn'B flavours, and the backbeat elevates the entire composition.

The song transitions to verse straight away, with a flow similar to that of the hook, but changes the motion mid-verse with longer aperture, creating a swell rhythmic variation. Hook repeats once more without any interludes or musical breaks and the next verse-like section also begins right after. This is followed by a bridge-like fraction where the drums are omitted for a while, which creates a dynamic break of shorts. The hook reappears one last time, ending the song on a slower pace without a beat, coming full-circle aesthetically as like the intro.

Currently the emcee is on a two-month tour with Dj Bishow. The tour is titled 'The Change with 5:55', playing across a dozen venues in the US. It is aimed at promoting his released and upcoming music projects. The first show of the tour shall be performed on Sunday at the Khatra DBE, Dallas to celebrate New Year's Eve 2024.



Kathy Griffin files for divorce ahead of fourth wedding anniversary

AP
Los Angeles, Dec. 30

Comedian Kathy Griffin has filed for divorce from longtime partner Randy Bick just shy of the couple's fourth wedding anniversary.

Los Angeles Superior Court records show Griffin filed for divorce Thursday, citing irreconcilable differences.

The pair dated for several years before marrying on New Year's Day 2020. They have no children, and Griffin's filing says a prenuptial agreement dictates how their assets should be divided. Griffin, 63, was a star of the NBC series 'Suddenly Susan' and poked fun at her celebrity on 'My Life on the D-List.'

Bick has worked as a marketing executive and began dating Griffin in 2011.

Griffin was previously married. She accused her former husband of stealing from her on 'Larry King Live' in 2006, and says she put their troubles into her act.

The filing was first reported Friday by celebrity website TMZ.

Bollywood celebrates rocking year, riding high on action, unbridled masculinity and misogyny

BY VINEETA DEEPAK (AP)
New Delhi, Dec. 30



Bollywood has made a financial comeback this year worthy of one of its traditional singing-on-top-of-the-hills moments.

India's Hindi language movie industry made an impressive recovery after a pandemic-driven slowdown, audience fatigue with big studio productions and Bollywood megastars, and streaming platforms taking away a large chunk of viewership.

According to consultancy firm Ormax Media, the cumulative box office in 2023 pulled in US$ 1.3 billion, making it one of the best-grossing years of all time.

Indian moviegoers — both the masses and niche film lovers — are back in theatres and the massive commercial success of big-ticket Bollywood films has set at ease fears that Mumbai's glitzy dream factory was losing its shine.

As one of the largest film producers in the world, India rolls out more than 1,500 movies yearly, its diverse story-telling traditions reflected in its prolific cinematic entertainers.

The films that made the cut this year were a mixed bag of visual delights. Some portrayed the classic Bollywood larger-than-life spectacles, others were action-filled spy thrillers with top-billing movie stars. Many included stylised special effects, slickly choreographed romantic songs filmed in stunning locales, and pulsating music that had fans cheering and dancing in cinema halls.

More than anything, the year belonged to India's beloved superstar, Shah Rukh Khan, whose son was jailed amid controversy in a narcotics case in 2021 and subsequently cleared of the charges. Khan's global fandom welcomed him back like never before, with his movies pumping the box office numbers.

The year began with his movie 'Pathaan,' which made more than US$ 100 million worldwide, according to The Numbers website. Then came 'Jawan,' which raked in nearly US$ 136 million worldwide. And the year is ending with yet another, titled 'Dunki.'

"Very grateful to all the people around the world who have given me soooo much love as an entertainer," Khan recently posted on social media platform X, formerly known as Twitter.

"This year Shah Rukh Khan has almost single-handedly revived cinema, very similar to what Tom Cruise did in Hollywood with his 'Top Gun' last year," said Nikhil Taneja, co-founder of the youth-centred media organisation Yuvaa and host of the popular YouTube shows 'Be A Man, Yaar.'

Other blockbusters of the year include the heavily criticised 'Animal' featuring actor Ranbir Kapoor, 'Gadar 2' with actor Sunny Deol, and Salman Khan's 'Tiger 3.'

It was also a year when hyper-masculinity overwhelmed Bollywood, often wrapped in misogyny and aggressive nationalism.

Angry young men have always been a staple of Indian movies but the excessive, fantasised screen violence this year took it to another level. Almost all 2023 Bollywood hits were filled with anger and violence, and led by alpha male protagonists with rippling muscles and blazing guns brandished on screen as they went on a bone-crunching rampage to vanquish their enemies.

Even Shah Rukh Khan, known as the king of romance, embraced the gun and gore while playing a spy fighting a militant outfit in 'Pathaan' and a vigilante battling institutional injustices in 'Jawan.'

While Khan's soft machismo remained nurturing and women-friendly even in his action flicks, many critics slammed the superhit movie 'Animal' directed by Sandeep Reddy Vanga for glorifying the toxic masculinity and misogyny of its twisted leading man. The film is moving toward a US$ 100-million run at box offices worldwide, its production company, Bhadrakali Pictures, said.

"Violent men do exist in the real world and a violent man can certainly be the central character in a film — the issue here, as always, is the manner of the portrayal, the script's indulgence towards him, the humour and coolth written into his fictional character, and the various means used to give him an allure despite his violent ways," film critic and author Anna MM Vetticad wrote in a blog post.

India has the world's largest young population, who also make up the majority of movie watchers. In a country where movie stars have a cult-like following, and movies reflect as well as shape mass behaviour, making dehumanising violence and casual sexism aspirational can be damaging, observers said.

The country's National Crime Records Bureau reported more than 445,000 cases of crimes against women in 2022, an increase of 4 per cent. 'Cruelty by Husband or Relatives' accounted for more than 31 per cent of such crimes, the report said.

"Today what we see is the detachment of violence from emotional purpose," in the movies, wrote social commentator Santosh Desai in the Times of India newspaper. "Given that politically, there is great comfort with maintaining more traditional gender roles, this emphatic assertion of masculinity might take us back in time."

Taneja, the Yuvaa organization co-founder, has been holding roadshows to reach out to young Indians about what he calls "positive masculinity." He said some films "feed into every single bias" of the viewer, whether it was misogyny or a villain of a different religion.

"When they see such films, they can relate to what they see in their homes where their fathers are misogynistic. They are patriarchal to their mothers. They see a certain kind of gender imbalance and they start believing it," he said. However, other successful films this year showcased a less angry, more accommodative masculinity, said Taneja.

Karan Johar's "Rocky aur Rani kii Prem Kahaani," or "Rocky and Rani's love story," won praise from most critics for its gender politics and for challenging male stereotypes and prejudices. The film went on to make nearly $45 million at box offices worldwide, according to the Bollywood Hungama website.

The answer lies in steering the public discourse away from movies that "aim to provoke only for the act of triggering," toward those that espouse other versions of modern Indian masculinity, Taneja said. "We need to have more conversations about the alternates — positive, empathetic and gentle masculinity — and push them more."

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: There's never been a better time to be a better you. This is the perfect moment to get back on track for any goals you've been procrastinating recently. Whether you could benefit from getting more sleep, setting up a cleaner diet.

TAURUS: Enjoying yourself is your top priority for the day. Put most of your work on the back burner and indulge in whatever you please. Even if you can't completely clear your plate.

GEMINI: There's no need to rush out the door to confront the outside world. Instead, you can stay hunkered down indoors. Nesting into warm blankets probably sounds delightful.

CANCER: The velvet rope is lifting to let you in. Social delights are everywhere, stirring up the energy and plenty of opportunities to head out and enjoy yourself. You could discover some great spots around the town with old friends .

LEO: You deserve a little pampering before the clock strikes midnight. Perhaps it's browsing the seasonal sales for a bit of year-end shopping or splurging on a fancy bottle of champagne to toast the arrival of the new year.

VIRGO: It's the perfect moment to focus on yourself. The best thing to do would be sitting down and pondering what you'd like to achieve in the coming year. You don't have to make resolutions.

LIBRA: You don't have to stay up until midnight if you don't want to. Even if you have plans to rage all night, you may still find yourself feeling a bit out of touch with reality mid-party.

SCORPIO: There's time for one last party before 2023 comes to an end! This is a wonderful day to come together with friends, old and new. The last thing you should do is play it safe and hide your spark.

SAGITTARIUS: Even if everyone else is thinking about how to party the night away, you may feel drawn to get started on your plans for 2024. While your pals or family are busy out on the town.

CAPRICORN: Throw open the door and let in the light! As much as you may want to party with friends and family right now, consider searching for different ways to invigorate your celebrations with a touch of something fresh.

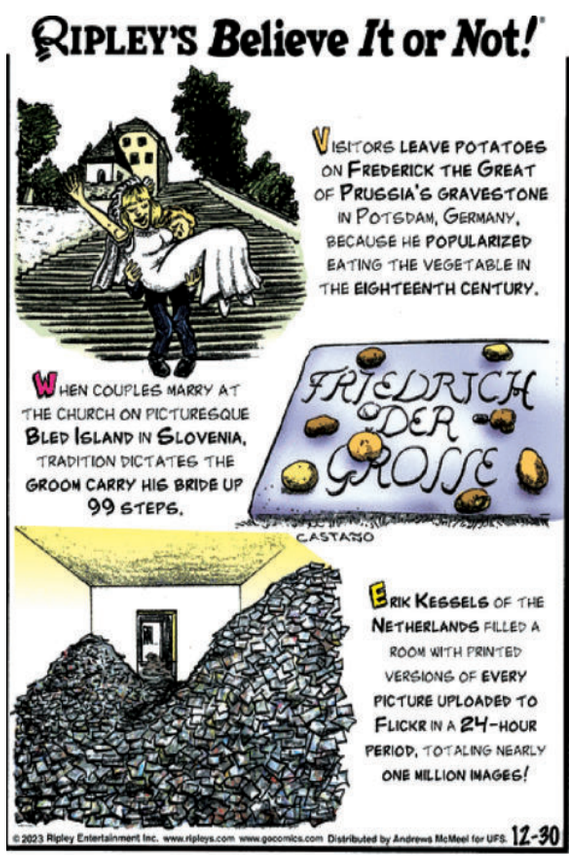
AQUARIUS: Everyone else may seem ready to go out and party, but you're potentially feeling something else entirely. Your mood is taking a private turn, so don't worry if a big get-together sounds rather unappealing.

PISCES: You only need one person by your side to ring in the next year! You may, however, also decide to be on the lookout for a potential new partner-in-crime. Whether you've already got one by your side or plan to seek one out before midnight.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





Lalitpur City crowned NSL Season 2 champions



PHOTO: BIKAS DWARE/TRN
Lalitpur City FC was crowned the NSL Season 2 champions on Saturday.

BY NAYAK PAUDEL
Kathmandu, Dec. 30

Lalitpur City Football Club won the second edition of the Nepal Super League beating Dhangadhi FC 3-2 at an exorbitantly packed Dasharath Stadium on Saturday.

The league organisers were however seen neglected towards a properly organised game. People with tickets in their hands were blocked entrance from the gate behind Block A of the stadium as the organisers closed the doors at around 5:40 pm.

After a commotion which was difficult for the guards and police to control, the gates were opened without checking for tickets. However, people stormed in, with many screaming in pain, some searching for their lost shoes and some crushed near the gates. Nevertheless, Dhangadhi, who had lost the trophy in the first edition to Kathmandu Rayzrs, lost the final once again to a Kathmandu Valley-based club.

Dhangadhi was seen as more dominant in the first half as the first goal came from Olawale Afeez in the 38th minute. However, the team started losing momentum after leading first.

Before the first-half whistle, Lalitpur equalised as Imoh Ezekiel scored on a freekick from outside the 18-yard box.

Sesehang Angdembe missed a quality chance within a minute of the start of the second half. However, in the 50th minute, Sesehang provided a mesmerising through pass to Aditya Shakya on the left flank. Shakya then provided a pass inside the box for Dinesh Henjan to lead the team 2-1. Shakya was the player of the match in the finals.

Papa Ibou Kebe, who was everywhere on the field for Lalitpur, helped in the third goal of the match. A poor clearance by the defender was sent back towards the goalkeeper by Kebe in the 58th minute. The rebound was sent towards the net by an acrobatic bicycle kick by Ezekiel for his second goal of the match.

Ezekiel, who scored five goals in the last three matches, was also awarded the Golden Boot.

Dhangadhi was reduced to 10 men after defender Richard was sent off after a double yellow in the 79th minute. Lalitpur then dominated possession until the end.

However, Jeffery Baltus, who was adjudged as the best goalkeeper of the season, was beaten once again in the 90+ injury time as Dhangadhi scored the second. Ahmad Hijazi was able to head a cross for the goal. Nevertheless, it was not enough.

Lalitpur's captain Ananta Tamang, who was awarded the most valuable player in the tournament, was one of the happiest faces on the field after the win till the team lifted the trophy.

The winner was given a cash prize of Rs. 7 million.



PHOTO: PRO CLUB CHAMPIONSHIP
Anil Sah of Nepal Police Club faces a ball in the final match of Pro Club Championship against Parsa Club at Birgunj on Saturday.

Nepal Police win Nepal Pro Club Championship

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 30

Nepal Police Club won the Nepal Pro Club Championship being held in Birgunj after winning by 100 runs against Parsa Club XI on Saturday. The championship started on December 21.

Nepal Police gave a target of 146 as Karan KC remained not out after scoring 40 runs off 17 balls. In a game where Parsa's main bowler Sandeep Lamichhane remained absent, five Nepal Police batsmen scored in two digits.

Yet, Saifullah Ansari and Pawan Sarraf took two wickets each, and Rupesh Singh and Ranjit Kumar took a wicket each. However, only one Parsa Club's batsman could score in two digits. Anil Shah's 13 runs in 12 balls was the highest score for Parsa as Sagar Dhakal took four wickets for the title winner.

Similarly, Lalit Rajbanshi and Rashid Khan took two wickets each, and Karan KC and Sher Malla took a wicket each to bowl out Parsa at 45 runs in only 11 overs.

In 15 league matches of the 20-over Nepal Pro Club Championship, only one match saw a score of over 150 runs in an inning. Nepal Army Club gave the target of 160 to Parsa Club XI on the 8th match of the league stage.

While the majority of the matches ended with low scores, Nepal Army showed why the team was good with bat as they won against Wonders Club Noida on Saturday to grab the third position in the championship.

The match started late due to fog in Birgunj, a Tarai area, leading match officials to reduce the 3rd place playoff to seven overs each. Electing to bat first, Noida posted a target of 75 in losing three wickets. Noida's batsmen hit six sixes with Harshit Sethi (25 runs in 10 balls) hitting two. Sethi remained not out at a strike rate of 250. Shahab Alam took all three wickets for Nepal Army, but he was also beaten for 17 runs in his spell of two overs.

Nepal Army lost four wickets but got to the target in 6.3 overs. Four batsmen had a strike rate of 200 and over, and they also hit six sixes in the chase. Sandeep Rajali ran twice for two to win the match for Nepal Army and remained not out as the highest scorer for the team with 23 runs off 10 balls. Ritik Vats took two wickets and Prashant Gujjar and Alipt Gupta took one each for Noida.

The six-team championship has now come to an end.

APF unbeaten throughout league stage, facing Koshi at Qualifier 1 for the finals

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 30

Armed Police Force (APF) completed its league-stage campaign of the PM Cup Women's National Cricket Tournament unbeaten. APF, who is also the title defender, won by 47 runs against Bagmati Province on the final day of the league stages to enter the qualifiers and move forward for the title once again.

APF, which is in the top with 14 points, will face Koshi Province, the second-positioned team, for a place in the finals on December 31. Koshi won the final league match against Lumbini Province and has now 12 points.

Losing three wickets after batting first, Sita Rana Magar's 44 runs in 50 balls and Indu Barma's 28 off 22 helped APF set a target of 127 for Bagmati. However, Bagmati struggled against the bowling lineup of APF.

Chasing the target, Bagmati could only score 79 runs in 20 overs by losing eight wickets. Sony Pakhrin's 20 off 39 was the highest score for Bagmati. Suman Bist took two wickets and Karuna Bhandari took one for APF to help ensure they entered the qualifiers undefeated.

Sudur Pashchim Province also won the final match of the league stage against Gandaki in the morning session to stay in the third position with 10 points. Sudur Pashchim won the match by 24 runs as Gandaki could only reach 103 runs while chasing the target of 128.

Suman Khatiwada, who remained not out, fell only a run short of a half-century (49 off 48) but the score could not help Gandaki reach the target. Seemana KC remained not out with Suman by scoring 19 off 40. Gandaki only lost two wickets in the chase.

Samjhana Khadka was the highest scorer for Sudur Pashchim with 26 runs in 11 balls.

In the evening session, Koshi won the match with seven wickets against Lumbini. Lumbini could only score 69 in the loss of five wickets despite playing all the balls of the 20-over inning. Koshi chased the target of 70 runs with the help of 44 runs by captain Rubina Chhetry. She also took four wickets, bowled a maiden over and only gave seven runs.

Madhes Province also posted a low target to Karnali as it could only score 99 runs in the loss of seven wickets, mostly with the help of 49 runs in 50 balls by Puja Mahato and 18 runs in 41 balls by Saraswati Kumari.

However, Karnali was bowled out at only 21 runs in 9.4 overs in the chase as both Puja and Saraswati shined with the bowl as well. Puja took four wickets and Saraswati took three.

Now, APF and Koshi will face for a place in the finals on December 31. The loser will get another opportunity as it will play against the winner of Eliminator 1 (a match between third and fourth-positioned Sudur Pashchim and Bagmati respectively) at Qualifiers 2 for the finals.



PHOTO: CAN
APF players celebrate during their match against Bagmati on Friday.

WEATHER

Sunday

Sunrise at 6:54 am, Sunset at 5:19 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Sunday)

Partly to generally cloudy in the hilly regions of the country and partly cloudy to mainly fair in rest of the country. Possibility of light snowfall at a few places of the high hilly and mountainous region of the country.

Expected Temp.: 18 - 20°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Saturday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	17.2	5.3	0.0
Dipayal	24.5	6.5	0.0
Dhangadi	15.8	13.0	0.0
Birendranagar	23.6	6.9	0.0
Nepalgunj	14.8	12.8	0.0
Jumla	16.6	-5.5	0.0
Ghorahi	24.0	9.0	0.0
Pokhara	22.2	9.8	0.0
Bhairahawa	15.1	11.8	0.0
Simara	15.2	13.2	0.0
Kathmandu	19.4	6.7	0.0
Okhaldhunga	20.0	9.0	0.0
Taplejung	18.0	5.7	0.0
Dhankuta	24.3	9.5	0.0
Biratnagar	20.5	13.0	0.0
Jomsom	12.0	-3.0	0.0*
Dharan	27.4	12.0	0.0*
Lumle	17.6	6.5	0.0*
Janakpur	16.0	14.6	0.0*
Jiri	16.1	1.5	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

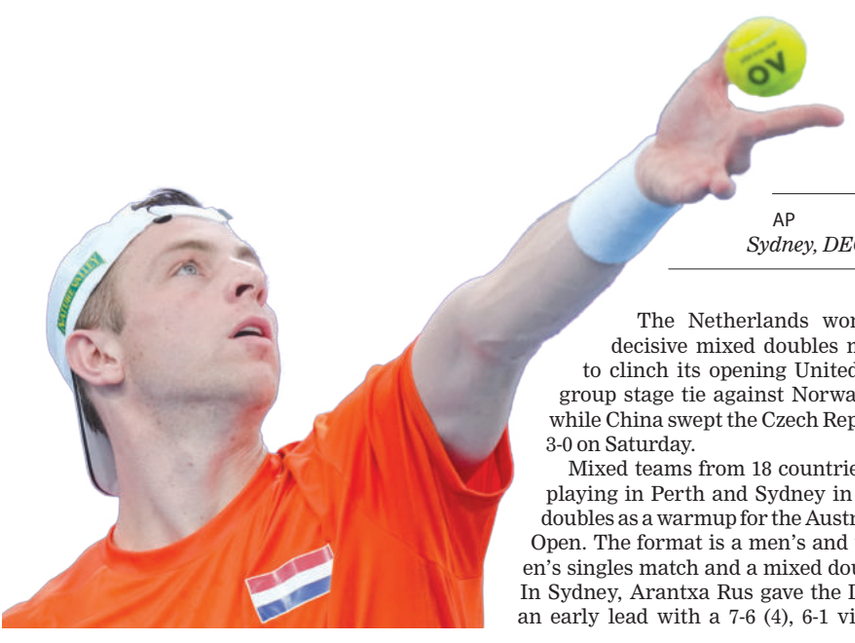
December 31, 2023

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.84	Rs. 133.44
Euro	1	Rs. 146.95	Rs. 147.61
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 169.10	Rs. 169.86
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 158.39	Rs. 159.10
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 90.28	Rs. 90.69
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 100.21	Rs. 100.66
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 100.67	Rs. 101.12
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.37	Rs. 9.41
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.68	Rs. 18.77
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.42	Rs. 35.58
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.44	Rs. 36.61
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.87	Rs. 3.89
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.17	Rs. 36.33
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.91	Rs. 29.04
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.21	Rs. 10.26
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.25	Rs. 13.31
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.72	Rs. 19.81
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 17.01	Rs. 17.08
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 432.28	Rs. 434.23
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.37	Rs. 353.97

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.



Netherlands and China win opening group stage matches at United Cup

AP
Sydney, DEC. 31

The Netherlands won the decisive mixed doubles match to clinch its opening United Cup group stage tie against Norway 2-1, while China swept the Czech Republic 3-0 on Saturday.

Mixed teams from 18 countries are playing in Perth and Sydney in what doubles as a warmup for the Australian Open. The format is a men's and women's singles match and a mixed doubles. In Sydney, Arantxa Rus gave the Dutch an early lead with a 7-6 (4), 6-1 victory over Malene Helgø, before No.11 Casper Ruud leveled the tie for the Norwegians by beating Tallon Griekspoor 6-3, 6-4.

Dutch pair Demi Schuurs and Wesley Koolhof then won the decisive mixed doubles match against Ruud and Ulrikke Eikeri 7-6(5), 7-5 to take the Group F tie.

In the Group E match in Perth, China raced to a 2-0 lead after Zhang Zhizhen rallied to beat Jiri Lehecka 5-7, 6-3, 6-4 and Zheng Qinwen upset No. 7 Marketa Vondrousova 6-1, 2-6, 6-1. The Chinese pair then sealed a 3-0 clean-sweep of tie by winning the mixed doubles.

Former Australian Open champion Angelique Kerber made her return to the court after giving birth in February in a 6-4, 7-5 defeat to Italy's Jasmine Paoline in Germany's opening Group D match in Sydney.

Kerber is joined in the German team by No. 7 Alexander Zverev, who faces Lorenzo Sonego in an evening match. Later Saturday in Perth, women's No. 1 Iga Swiatek takes to the court for Poland's opening Group A match against Brazil. Swiatek faces No. 11 Beatrice Haddad Maia, before Hubert Hurkacz plays Thiago Seyboth Wild in the men's match.

Brazil lost its opening match against Spain 2-1 on Friday.

On Sunday, men's No. 1 Novak Djokovic returns to Perth for the first time since the Hopman Cup in 2013 when he leads Serbia in its first group stage match against China.

Djokovic won three Grand Slam singles titles this year, missing out on only Wimbledon. He's preparing to try and win the Australian Open for a record-extending 11th time.

Published by Executive Chairman **Bishnu Prasad Subedi** and General Manager **Lal Bahadur Airi** for the Gorkhapatra Corporation • Printed at G.S. Press, Kathmandu • Acting Editor-in-Chief: **Bhimsen Thapaliya**
Phone: Editorial 5322279 • Advertisement 5327493, 5331394 • Distribution 5320638 • E-mail: mgorkhapatra@gmail.com, trnfeatures@hotmail.com • Registered No. 29/028/022 • G.P.O. 30/053/54